

Resource: Study Notes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Study Notes (Tyndale)

JHN

John 1:1

Echoing [Gen 1:1](#), John's Gospel introduces Jesus Christ, through whom God created everything ([John 1:3](#)); Jesus also creates new life in those who believe ([1:12-13](#)). The Gospel opens with its central affirmation, that Jesus Christ, the Word (Greek *logos*), not only revealed God but was God. In Greek thought, the *logos* was the rational principle guiding the universe and making life coherent. For Jewish people, the *logos* was the word of the Lord, an expression of God's wisdom and creative power. By Jesus' time, the *logos* was viewed as coming from God and having his personality (see [Ps 33:6, 9](#); [Prov 8:22-31](#)); John affirmed this understanding ([John 1:14](#)).

John 1:1-18

The beginning of this prologue ([1:1-5](#)) might be a poem or hymn sung by the earliest Christians. The prologue's themes—the coming of the light into the world, the rejection of the light, and its gift of new life to believers—prepares readers for the story that follows.

John 1:3

The *logos* is God ([1:1-2](#)); all that God does, the *logos* likewise does. Throughout his Gospel, John rightly viewed Jesus' actions as divine activity.

John 1:4

The Word gave life: Life was God's original gift to his creatures ([Gen 1:20-28](#); [2:7](#)). Now the *logos* would give these creatures the possibility of new life through rebirth ([John 1:13](#)). • As one of his first creative acts, God brought light ([Gen 1:3](#)). Now, in

the re-creation of humanity through Jesus Christ, God offered light and life anew. Light is a key theme in John's Gospel.

John 1:4-5

God created light and dispelled the darkness ([Gen 1:2-5](#)). The darkness resists God ([John 3:19-21](#); [12:35](#); [Matt 6:23](#); [Acts 26:17-18](#); [Eph 4:17-19](#); [5:7-14](#); [2 Pet 1:19](#); [1 Jn 1:5-7](#); [2:9-11](#)).

John 1:5

the darkness can never extinguish it: Or *the darkness has not understood it*; literally *the darkness cannot grasp it*. The Greek word *katalambanō* ("grasp") can mean either "understand" or "be hostile"; in John's Gospel, it means hostility. The darkness would try to destroy Jesus (the light), but it would fail. The light would successfully bring salvation to the world.

John 1:6-9

God sent a man, John the Baptist, to herald Jesus' coming and to prepare God's people to receive Jesus as God's Son and Messiah (see [1:19-37](#); [Luke 1:5-25](#), [57-80](#); [3:1-22](#); see also [Isa 40:3](#); [Mal 4:5-6](#)).

John 1:8

Some Jews speculated that John the Baptist was the Messiah; some of his followers were even reluctant to follow Jesus ([3:22-30](#)). However, John the Baptist was not the light; his role was to announce Jesus ([1:19-34](#)).

John 1:10

The world cannot recognize the true light even when it encounters its Creator. The world lives in rebellion, loving darkness more than light ([3:19](#)).

John 1:12

Only through divine renewal can people follow the light and enter God's family ([3:1-17](#)). • Individuals must believe in Christ to become children of God ([12:35-36](#)).

John 1:13

a birth that comes from God: People can escape the darkness only by God's grace ([8:12](#); [12:35-36](#), [44-46](#)).

John 1:14

The idea that the Word became human (literally *became flesh*) stunned both Greeks and Jews. Greeks separated the sphere of God from the mundane world of humanity, which they called *flesh* (Greek *sarx*). John wrote that God himself became *flesh* in Christ (cp. [1:1](#)). Jesus' humanity and divinity were complete, not partial. The two ideas—Jesus as 100-percent divine and 100-percent human—form the bedrock of a Christian understanding of Christ. • the Word . . . made his home (Greek *skēnoō*, "pitched his tent") among us: This Greek word is related to the word used for the Old Testament Tabernacle (Greek *skēnē*, "tent, tabernacle"), the tent in the wilderness where the Lord's glory resided and where Israel came to worship ([Exod 25:8-9](#)). The Father's glory in the Tabernacle ([Exod 40:34-38](#)) was now present in Jesus Christ ([John 2:11](#); [12:23-28](#), [41](#); [17:1-5](#)). • Jesus offered God's unfailing love and faithfulness. Despite the world's hostile darkness, Jesus entered the world to save it ([3:15-17](#)).

John 1:15

he existed long before me: In a society where age was respected and honored ([Lev 19:32](#); contrast [Isa 3:5](#)), John the Baptist emphasized Jesus' honor by pointing to his existence even before creation ([John 1:1-3](#)).

John 1:17

the law: That is, the *torah*, the body of instruction given to Moses at Mount Sinai. • Although God's unfailing love and faithfulness are in the torah, these qualities are fully revealed in Christ ([3:16](#); [13:1](#)).

John 1:18

Moses was denied his desire to see God directly ([Exod 33:18-20](#)). Only Jesus has seen the Father, so he alone completely knows him and can tell us about him ([John 3:32-35](#); [14:9-10](#)). • But the unique One, who is himself God: The Son, who sees the Father, *is himself God*—not simply a messenger who knows something about God. John explicitly affirms Christ's deity. Jesus shares the substance of God's being.

John 1:19-51

John's Gospel gives limited attention to John the Baptist compared to the synoptic Gospels ([Matt 3:1-6](#); [Mark 1:2-6](#); [Luke 1:1-24](#), [57-80](#); [3:1-13](#)). Yet the apostle John wants us to see that John the Baptist correctly identified and exalted Jesus. John the Baptist's disciples leave him and follow Jesus; Jesus took over the ministry John began, increasing as John decreased ([John 3:30](#)).

John 1:19-12:50

Jesus reveals himself to the world through his miraculous signs and sermons. Audiences were divided: Some wanted to believe in him; others opposed him. This division intensifies as the book unfolds. Jesus ended his public ministry with a final appeal for people to believe in him ([12:44-50](#)).

John 1:20

The Jews expected the Messiah (the Hebrew form of the Greek word *Christ*) to bring spiritual leadership and political redemption to Israel (see [Deut 18:15](#); see also the Jewish intertestamental book *Psalms of Solomon*).

John 1:21

Elijah was to be the Messiah's forerunner ([Mal 4:5](#)). John the Baptist fulfilled the forerunner's role, though he denied being the prophet Elijah (see [Matt 11:14](#); [Luke 1:17](#)). • Are you the Prophet we are expecting? Cp. [John 6:14](#); [7:40-41](#).

John 1:22-23

Then who are you? John the Baptist simply wanted to be known as a voice shouting in the wilderness (see [Isa 40:3](#)).

John 1:24

The Pharisees were deeply devoted to the Scriptures and earnestly desired a righteous life. They also believed in the coming Messiah, which explains their inquiries here. Some Pharisees became believers in Jesus ([Acts 15:5](#)), including the apostle Paul ([Acts 26:5](#); [Phil 3:5](#)).

John 1:25-26

Jewish baptisms were ritual washings for becoming ceremonially pure following contact with impurity ([Lev 8:6](#); [Num 19:7](#)). • John's announcement of the Messiah's arrival required that participants confess their sins and be baptized ([Matt 3:6](#)). Baptism later became the symbol of membership in Jesus' kingdom ([Acts 2:38](#); see also [John 4:1-2](#)).

John 1:27

A menial task such as removing a sandal was reserved for a slave; these tasks were never performed by a disciple.

John 1:29

The phrase Lamb of God might refer to the Passover sacrifice of a lamb or to the daily sacrifice in the Temple ([Exod 29:38-46](#); [Heb 10](#)). See also [Rev 5](#).

John 1:32

John the Baptist's second testimony (see [1:19-23](#)) told what happened when Jesus was baptized. • In the Old Testament, kings and prophets were anointed with the Holy Spirit, but these anointings were temporary and tied to a particular office or occasion. By contrast, with the Spirit's resting on him, Jesus' anointing was permanent (see [3:34](#)).

John 1:34

the Chosen One of God: See [Isa 42:1](#).

John 1:35-51

This section introduces the template for discipleship in John's Gospel. Disciples desired to come and see Jesus ([1:39](#)), and when they encountered him, they remained with him.

John 1:40-42

Simon is well known in the Gospels, not for his courage and faith, but for his failings (see [18:15-18](#), [25-27](#)). Jesus named him Cephas ("the rock"), referring to the great church leader he would later become (see [Acts 1:1-5:42](#); [8:1-12:25](#); [15:1-41](#)).

John 1:43-44

Galilee was the region of northern Israel around the Sea of Galilee. • Bethsaida ("house of fishing") was a village on Galilee's north shore and the home of Peter, Andrew, and Philip. Later, Peter and Andrew moved to Capernaum, a village west of Bethsaida ([Mark 1:21, 29](#)).

John 1:45

Philip, a Greek name, and Nathanael, a Hebrew name, represent the mix of cultures in Galilee. Jesus' message there addressed both audiences. When Greeks wanted to see Jesus in Jerusalem, they approached Philip ([12:20-22](#)). • Jesus grew up in Nazareth, a mountain village southwest of the Sea of Galilee.

John 1:46

Can anything good come from Nazareth? This village was not considered famous enough to be the hometown for a great leader (cp. [Matt 13:53–58](#)).

John 1:47

Jesus referred to Nathanael as a man of complete integrity, contrasting him with Jacob, the scheming, deceitful patriarch whom God renamed Israel (see [Gen 25:27–34](#); [27:1–36](#); [32:22–32](#)). It is as though Nathanael embodied God's ideal for Israel.

John 1:48–49

Jesus captured Nathanael's attention by knowing his character ([1:47](#)), then he captured his worship by supernaturally knowing his previous actions. Nathanael witnessed a miracle and took a remarkable step of faith.

John 1:51

I tell you the truth (Greek *amēn amēn*): Jesus often used this expression to emphasize what he was about to say. In John's Gospel, the Greek word *amēn* is always doubled. • you will all see heaven open: Jesus made the comparison with Jacob explicit (see study note on 1:47; see [Gen 28:10–22](#)). Like Jacob, Nathanael would see God at work. Jesus himself is the new Bethel ("house of God," [Gen 28:19](#)), the place where God lives. • Son of Man: See study note on John 9:35; see also [Dan 7:13–14](#); [Mark 8:31](#). • John the apostle used several names for Jesus (Son of God, Son of Man, Messiah). Knowing Jesus' true identity is necessary to fully understanding and following him.

John 2:1

The ceremonies surrounding a wedding celebration could last as long as a week; weddings often included dramatic processions in which the groom would bring the bride to his home for the festivities ([Matt 25:1–13](#)).

John 2:1–25

In this section, Jesus appeared at two symbolic Jewish ceremonies. At a wedding in Cana ([2:1–12](#)), he replaced the ritual cleansing water with his own superior wine. Later, around Passover, he cleansed the Temple ([2:13–25](#)).

John 2:1–10.42

Jesus illustrated his identity and work through the institutions and festivals of Judaism (see [2:1](#); [5:1](#)).

John 2:3

When the wine supply ran out, the host's family would face embarrassment for failure to plan properly. Perhaps Jesus arrived unexpectedly (cp. [Matt 25:1–13](#)), bringing his circle of disciples, which might explain why his mother brought the problem to him. • A wedding banquet was a primary celebration in Jewish village life, and this episode also symbolized the joy of the Messiah's arrival.

John 2:4

Jesus initially distanced himself from the problem. His mission and its timing could not be set by a human agenda. • Jesus' time (literally *hour*) would come in the future when he was glorified as he was lifted up on the cross ([12:23](#); [17:1](#)).

John 2:6

Carved from solid rock, the stone water jars were used for religious washing ceremonies (see [Mark 7:1–4](#)). Jesus was about to fill Jewish ceremony with new content.

John 2:9–10

The master of ceremonies cited a proverb. The best wine was always served first when palates were most sensitive; yet this miraculous wine, served last, was the very best. Good wine symbolized God's blessing ([Amos 9:13–14](#)). The Messiah, God's greatest blessing, had arrived at last.

John 2:11

Jesus had offered his first miraculous sign. In it, he revealed the glory of God (see also [1:14](#); [11:4](#), [40](#)).

John 2:13

Passover, an annual spring festival, commemorated Israel's rescue from slavery in Egypt ([Exod 12](#)). Jews traveled to Jerusalem to participate in the festival ([Deut 16:1-16](#)). Because John refers to three Passover festivals ([John 2:13](#); [6:4](#); [11:55](#)), many conclude that Jesus had a three-year public ministry.

John 2:14-17

Those who came for Passover needed to have approved sacrifices for worship. From this need grew a considerable industry for selling animals and exchanging money, but this business was being conducted in the Temple. Jesus, like a prophet, demanded that God's house be returned to its intended uses—worship, prayer, instruction, and sacrifice. This put Jesus at odds with the Temple leadership. • The synoptic Gospels place the clearing of the Temple near the end of Jesus' ministry ([Matt 21:12-13](#); [Mark 11:15-17](#); [Luke 19:45-46](#)). John might have placed his account of the event here to emphasize a connection with the miracle that transformed the water in purification jars into wine ([John 2:1-11](#)). The Temple and the stone jars were both instruments of purification in Judaism. Stone jars filled with water for ritual washing now contained Jesus' wine, and a stone Temple dedicated to sacrificial purification would be replaced by Christ himself ([2:19-21](#)). Another view is that Jesus cleared the Temple at the beginning and again at the end of his ministry.

John 2:19-21

Destroy this temple: Herod the Great began reconstructing the Temple's magnificent structure in 20 BC, and work on it continued until AD 64. This explains why Jesus' audience was amazed when he claimed he could destroy and rebuild it in a few days. However, Jesus spoke figuratively of his own body as the temple where God was present (see

[1:14](#), [51](#))—his body was destroyed and restored in three days through the resurrection, rendering the Jerusalem Temple and its services obsolete. Later, at his trial, Jesus' symbolic reference to destroying the Temple was used as evidence of blasphemy ([Mark 14:58](#)).

John 2:22

they believed: Witnessing a miracle from God can inspire belief, but it is not the deepest faith possible ([20:29](#)).

John 2:24

John uses a play on words here. Because of his signs, many people trusted in Jesus ([2:23](#)), but Jesus didn't trust them. This did not refer to specific people Jesus met in Jerusalem, but reflects his knowledge of all humanity.

John 3:1

John links [2:25](#) and [3:1](#) by referring to humanity as a whole ("human nature," [2:25](#)) and then to one specific man using the same Greek word (anthrōpos) in both verses. • Nicodemus was saturated in religious knowledge and had witnessed Jesus' work ([2:13-24](#)), but he had not experienced spiritual rebirth. • a Pharisee: See study note on 1:24. He was elite, proud of his spiritual purity, and well educated in Jewish law.

John 3:2

After dark: Nicodemus might have feared public association with Jesus. Night also symbolizes the realm of evil, untruth, and unbelief ([9:4](#); [11:10](#); [13:30](#)).

John 3:3

born again: Or *born from above*. John's expression "from above" ([3:31](#); [19:11](#)) means "from God." To experience spiritual rebirth, a person must be completely renewed through God's power. • Nicodemus interpreted Jesus' words physically; he demonstrated that those in darkness, who do not have spiritual rebirth, cannot understand Jesus or

other “heavenly things” ([3:12](#)). Jesus sometimes used ironic misunderstanding as a teaching strategy.

John 3:5

John the Baptist baptized with water; Jesus baptizes with the Spirit ([1:33](#)).

John 3:8

Wind translates the same word in Greek as *spirit* (Greek *pneuma*). The wind is an apt image for the Spirit, who is sent from heaven and cannot be contained or controlled.

John 3:13

There is great distance between this world and heaven (see [1:51](#); [3:31](#); [6:38](#), [42](#)). Jesus bridged that distance, validating his divine status by defeating death and returning to heaven ([16:5–11](#)).

John 3:14–15

Jesus was lifted up on the cross so that all people could understand the way of salvation, look to him in faith, and have eternal life.

John 3:16

The truth that God loved the world is basic to Christian understanding ([1 Jn 4:9–10](#)). God’s love extends beyond the limits of race and nation, even to those who oppose him (see “The World” Theme Note). • The Son came to save—not condemn ([3:17](#))—men and women who habitually embrace the darkness ([3:19–21](#)).

John 3:16–21

Because there are no quotation marks around Jesus’ speech in the Greek text, translators debate where Jesus’ speech ends and John’s commentary begins; [3:16–21](#) might be John’s commentary.

John 3:18

As light penetrates and exposes the world’s darkness, God’s judgment on the world has already begun. Those who see this light and recognize the tragedy of their own situation have the responsibility of believing in God’s . . . Son ([3:16–17](#)).

John 3:19–20

When people live in spiritual darkness, they do not desire to be enlightened by Jesus, “the light of the world” ([8:12](#); [9:5](#)). Evil and darkness do not ignore the light; they wage war against it, trying to bring it down. But the darkness cannot extinguish the light ([1:5](#)). Those who refuse to believe live in darkness (cp. [13:30](#)) and stumble because they cannot see ([11:10](#)). In the end, however, their sins will be exposed ([5:28–30](#); [Rev 20:11–15](#)).

John 3:22

Jesus spent some time . . . baptizing: See [4:2](#), which clarifies that Jesus’ disciples did the baptizing.

John 3:22–36

John the Baptist identifies Jesus as the one who is truly from above ([3:31](#)); this requires John’s followers to shift their allegiance to Jesus.

John 3:24

Before John was thrown into prison (see [Matt 14:1–12](#); [Mark 1:14](#); [6:14–29](#); [Luke 3:19–20](#)), he and Jesus worked in close proximity at the Jordan River. Once John was arrested, Jesus moved north into Galilee ([Mark 1:14](#)).

John 3:26

everybody is going to him: Jesus’ popularity made some of John’s followers envious.

John 3:27-35

John the Baptist's speech was inspired by two issues: (1) Some had questioned the legitimacy of his baptism (see [1:26](#)), and (2) his disciples were concerned that people were beginning to follow Jesus instead of John ([3:26](#)).

John 3:29

John the Baptist saw Jesus as the bridegroom and himself as the bridegroom's friend. His response deflected glory from himself and elevated Jesus' stature.

John 3:31

Jesus had come from above, so he was uniquely able to reveal the Father ([1:18](#); [3:13](#)).

John 3:34-35

The Father gives the Son the Spirit without limit as a sign of his profound love ([3:35](#)). It also illustrates Jesus' divinity. John presents the one God as three persons (cp. [1 Jn 5:5-12](#)).

John 3:36

God gave the gift of eternal life, promising new life and intimacy in a present experience with God. • Those who reject the Son will not see life. The world in its darkness stands under God's angry judgment ([Rom 1-3](#)).

John 4:1-42

At a historic well in Samaria, Jesus offered himself as living water. Jesus engaged and confronted people with the revelation of God, and they either followed or fell away. • The Samaritan woman contrasted with Nicodemus at every turn: a woman (not a man), a Samaritan (not a Jew), a sinner (not righteous), and an outcast (not one of Israel's rabbis). While Nicodemus fell silent and never responded to Jesus' challenges ([3:1-21](#)), this woman acknowledged Jesus as Lord, remained in the light, and exhibited signs of discipleship (see [1:35-51](#)).

John 4:2

Jesus himself didn't baptize anyone but left water baptism to his disciples. After his glorification on the cross ([7:37-39](#)), Jesus baptized people in the Holy Spirit ([1:33](#); [Acts 2:4](#)).

John 4:3

After John the Baptist had been imprisoned (see [Mark 6:14-29](#)), Jesus left Judea (cp. [Mark 1:14](#)).

John 4:4-6

In going north to Galilee, Jesus took the less-preferred route through Samaria. Samaria had a long history of tension with Judea (see [2 Kgs 17:24-41](#); [Ezra 4:1-5](#); [Neh 4](#); [6:1-19](#)). In Jesus' day, harsh racial and cultural conflict existed between Jews and Samaritans. Jews normally avoided Samaria by first going east to Jericho, then following the Jordan Valley north. • Sychar was probably in the region of Shechem. Jesus had come to Jacob's well; Jacob had owned land near Shechem ([Gen 33:18-19](#)).

John 4:7

Due to the heat, it was customary for the women to draw water in early morning or evening. However, this woman lived in isolation, separated from her community. Jesus was compassionate toward outcasts.

John 4:9

The woman was surprised because social taboos would keep a Jewish teacher like Jesus from speaking to her ([4:18](#)). However, Jesus did not let social taboos constrain him from giving her what she truly needed.

John 4:10

Shechem had no rivers and thus no living water (see "Living Water" Theme Note). However, Jesus

was speaking symbolically: This gift from God was the Holy Spirit ([7:37-39](#)).

John 4:11

Jacob's well was more than 100 feet (30 meters) deep and required a long rope for drawing water. The woman misunderstood Jesus' words because she was still in darkness.

John 4:12

Our father Jacob: The Samaritan woman respected the holy traditions related to the well more than the presence of God in front of her.

John 4:14

The notion of a fresh, bubbling spring was a powerful image in the dry climate of Israel. Those who come to God will neither hunger nor thirst (see [Isa 49:10](#); [55:1-3](#); [Jer 2:13](#)).

John 4:15

The woman asked Jesus for this water, but she did not grasp the spiritual implications of his words. To overcome the spiritual barrier, Jesus addressed her sin ([4:16-18](#)).

John 4:16-18

Immorality blocked the woman's understanding. Her marital affairs, including having five husbands, underscored her sinful life.

John 4:19

a prophet: Jesus revealed knowledge about the woman ([4:16-18](#)) that was inaccessible to the average person (cp. [1:48](#)). • As the woman's understanding of Jesus unfolded, her names for him became increasingly well informed. Earlier she recognized him as *a Jew* ([4:9](#)) and called him *sir* ([4:11](#), [15](#), [19](#)). Later she thought he might be *the Messiah* ([4:29](#)). Finally, the people of the village recognized him as *Savior of the world* ([4:42](#)). Her

growing understanding of Jesus' identity is a testimony to John's readers (see [20:31](#)).

John 4:19-20

The woman dodged Jesus' moral probing and brought up the historical ethnic division between Jews and Samaritans.

John 4:20

The Samaritans worshiped at Mount Gerizim, which towered above Shechem. Both were important Old Testament locations (see [Gen 12:6-7](#); [33:19](#); [Deut 11:29](#); [Josh 8:33](#); [24:1](#), [25](#), [32](#)).

John 4:21-22

Jesus affirmed that the Jews had preserved the right understanding of the one you worship. • salvation comes through the Jews: God gave the Jews a special relationship with him, and the Messiah was to be a Jew (see also [Rom 9:4-5](#)).

John 4:24

in spirit and in truth: One Greek preposition governs both words (literally *in spirit and truth*) and makes them a single concept. True worship occurs as God's Spirit reveals God's truth and reality to the worshiper. Jesus Christ is the Truth ([14:6](#); cp. [14:17](#); [15:26](#)).

John 4:26

I Am the Messiah (Greek reads "*I am, the one speaking to you*"): Jesus' phrase was unusual and emphatic, and it suggests identity with God (see [8:58](#); [Exod 3:14](#)).

John 4:27-30

The woman was tentative about Jesus' identity ([4:29](#)), yet she ran to the village and told everyone to come and see. Testifying to others is a mark of discipleship (see [1:39](#), [46](#)).

John 4:32-34

While Jesus spoke to the Samaritan woman, the disciples were gone buying food ([4:8](#)); now they urged Jesus to eat. Jesus continued to speak symbolically, but they did not understand him ([4:33](#)). Later, when the disciples received the Spirit, they understood ([2:22](#)). Jesus received his nourishment from doing what his Father told him to do (see [5:30](#); [6:38](#); [7:18](#); [8:50](#); [9:4](#); [10:37-38](#); [12:49-50](#)).

John 4:35

Four months between planting and harvest: Jesus cited a local parable to contrast the natural harvest with his own. It was harvest time in Samaria, and the fields were ripe. Jesus, however, had planted seed at the well and now was already reaping the harvest of belief among the Samaritans ([4:39-42](#)).

John 4:38

others: Jesus might have meant John the Baptist, or he might have been referring to the work he had just done with the Samaritan woman.

John 4:39-40

Many Samaritans: The religiously sophisticated “chosen people” in Jerusalem did not respond to Jesus with faith (ch [3](#)). By contrast, many Samaritans believed in Jesus because of the testimony of this outcast woman.

John 4:42

The Samaritans had experienced for themselves that Jesus was true. Their name for Jesus, Savior of the world (also used in [1 Jn 4:14](#)), demonstrated that the Samaritans were keenly aware of their distance from Judaism. Jesus’ ministry was not simply for Jews, but for all people ([John 1:4-12](#); cp. [12:20-26](#)).

John 4:44-45

Unlike Jesus’ fellow Jews, the Galileans welcomed him, but their welcome was based on awe of Jesus’ miracles (cp. [2:23-25](#)), not true faith.

John 4:48

Jesus sharply criticized the Galileans who desired miraculous signs and wonders before they would believe (see [6:30](#)).

John 4:50

Your son will live! Jesus also healed the centurion’s slave ([Matt 8:5-13](#)) and the Phoenician woman’s daughter ([Matt 15:21-28](#)) from a distance.

John 4:53

Just like many others ([2:23](#); [4:39](#)), the official and his household believed in Jesus because of the miracle.

John 4:54

second miraculous sign . . . in Galilee: Two miracles at Cana ([2:11](#); [4:46](#)) frame this section of John’s Gospel.

John 5:1

one of the Jewish holy days: Because Jesus returned to Jerusalem for the celebration, it was probably one of the three pilgrimage festivals of Judaism (see [Exod 23:14-17](#); [Deut 16:16](#)). These festivals lasted one week.

John 5:1-40

This chapter reads like a courtroom drama, with a description of the crime ([5:1-15](#)), followed by a decision to prosecute ([5:16](#)), a description of the charges ([5:18](#)), and Jesus’ defense ([5:17](#), [19-40](#)).

John 5:1–10.42

In this section Jesus appears at a series of Jewish festivals and uses their imagery to reveal more profound truths about himself. He appears at a Sabbath (ch [5](#)), Passover (ch [6](#)), the Festival of Shelters (chs [7–9](#)), and Hanukkah (ch [10](#)). In each case, Jesus himself replaces some vital element in the ceremonies of the festival.

John 5:2

Greek copyists who had never been to Jerusalem had difficulty interpreting and spelling the name Bethesda, so there are several variants of this name in the manuscripts. The best choice is *Beth-esda* ("house of flowing").

John 5:3

The pool of Bethesda had become a healing sanctuary for crowds of sick people who believed miraculous cures were possible. • Most scholars believe that the variant reading in the NLT textual note was not part of John's original text, but it represents an ancient tradition that provided helpful background information.

John 5:5

No social program helped this man, who had been ill for thirty-eight years. Hygiene and mobility were impossible, and he likely begged for a living from people who came to use the pool (see [5:7](#)). His situation seemed hopeless.

John 5:8–9

Jesus healed the sick man instantly, only asking for his obedience. As proof of healing, Jesus told him to pick up his mat and walk. • Jesus worked this miracle on the Sabbath, a weekly day of rest on which all work was prohibited (based on [Gen 2:2](#); [Exod 20:8](#)). Jewish tradition outlined thirty-nine categories of work that were not allowed (*Mishnah Shabbat* [7:2](#)). Carrying something such as a sleeping mat from one place to another was banned ([John 5:10](#)). Therefore, the healed man broke the tradition by obeying Jesus' command.

John 5:12

Who said such a thing? The plot ominously turns from miraculous wonder to Sabbath crime, precipitating a request for the identity of the healer who breached tradition.

John 5:14

stop sinning: Though the man had been healed physically, he still needed to learn obedience to the Lord. The man's next action ([5:15](#)) might indicate that he didn't listen.

John 5:17

My Father is always working, and so am I: Although work was prohibited on the Sabbath, even rabbis agreed that God worked on the Sabbath in giving life (births) and in taking life (deaths). The heart of Jesus' defense was to compare himself to God; the Jewish leaders objected to this claim of divine privilege.

John 5:19–30

Jesus claimed that his work on the Sabbath was the same as God's work on the Sabbath. Jesus claimed to be equal with God, doing the things God does. Yet he submitted to God's will, doing only what . . . the Father willed.

John 5:21

Most Jews firmly believed in resurrection but viewed it as something God alone could accomplish. Jesus claimed that he gives life.

John 5:22

In addition to giving life, Jesus claimed the absolute authority to judge, which belongs to God alone.

John 5:23

the Father . . . sent him: In the ancient world, a person could send an authorized representative to seal a contract or make an authoritative decision.

Jesus claimed to be God's representative, so obeying Jesus is the same as obeying God, and dishonoring him is dishonoring God.

John 5:24

Jesus is the giver of life as well as the judge (see [5:21-22](#)), but he never works independently of the Father.

John 5:31-40

God's law requires more than one witness in a trial ([Deut 17:6](#)), so Jesus acknowledged that his own testimony was admissible only when confirmed by other witnesses. Thus, he introduced a series of witnesses for his defense.

John 5:32

The first witness for Jesus' defense was God himself. Jesus might have had in mind God's voice at his baptism ([Mark 1:11](#)) or the presence of God that enabled Jesus to perform miracles.

John 5:33-35

Jesus' second witness was John the Baptist, who pointed to Jesus as Messiah ([1:29-34](#)).

John 5:36

Jesus' third witness, his teachings and miracles, were signs that unveiled his true identity and pointed to the Father who sent him.

John 5:39-40

Jesus' fourth witness was the Scriptures. The Old Testament pointed to the Messiah, and Jesus fulfilled its prophecies (see [Luke 24:25-27](#)).

John 5:41-47

Jewish trials sought to discover the truth. Falsely accused defendants could not only prove their

innocence but also prosecute their accusers, which Jesus did here.

John 5:42

Jesus charged that the Jewish leaders did not have God's love within them. Without God's love, it was impossible for them to understand the things he was doing.

John 5:44

The Jewish leaders pursued honor and prestige from each other. They loved religious life, but they had forgotten to love God. This hypocrisy made them liable to judgment ([5:45-46](#)).

John 5:45-46

Jesus' fifth and final witness was Moses, the founding father of Judaism. John had already compared Jesus with Moses ([1:17](#); see also [6:14-15](#)). The Jewish leaders were ignoring Moses' clear words about the Messiah (e.g., [Deut 18:15](#)).

John 6:1-15

Jesus' feeding the 5,000 recalls the great Old Testament miracle of bread when Israel was in the wilderness ([Exod 16](#)). The rabbis of Jesus' day expected the coming Messiah to "rain down food from heaven" once again ([Exod 16:4](#)), and he did.

John 6:1-71

Each story in this chapter uses the setting of the Passover Festival ([6:4](#)) to communicate a deeper meaning.

John 6:5

Where can we buy bread: When the Israelites left Egypt following the first Passover and entered the desert, finding food and water was also their first concern ([Exod 15:22-16:3](#)).

John 6:9

Barley was the grain of the poor. The loaves were similar to pita bread. The two fish would have been salted, and with the five loaves of bread would make one meal.

John 6:10

The headcount of about 5,000 reflected the men alone ([Matt 14:21](#)), as social custom dictated. With women and children included, the total number was far greater.

John 6:11

The modest meal provided the crowd with as much as they wanted, echoing the miraculous provision of manna in the wilderness ([Exod 16:35](#)). Moses had first supplied Israel with heavenly bread; Jesus was the new supplier.

John 6:14

he is the Prophet we have been expecting! The crowd understood the miracle as a fulfillment of Old Testament promises (see [Deut 18:15, 18](#); [Mal 4:5-6](#)).

John 6:15

The people were ready to force Jesus to become their king. To avoid this role, Jesus fled the crowd and commanded his disciples to go back across the lake ([Mark 6:45-46](#)).

John 6:18

East-west winds blowing down over the eastern cliffs of the Sea of Galilee late in the day commonly caused very rough waters and turbulent storms.

John 6:19

The disciples' fear of the storm was now surpassed by their fear of Jesus, who came walking on the water to help them. This act recalled Moses, who

led Israel through the water ([Exod 14](#); see [Ps 77:19-20](#)).

John 6:20

I am here (Greek reads *I am*): Jesus identified himself by the name God had revealed to Moses on Mount Sinai (see [Exod 3:14](#); see also [John 4:26; 6:35](#)).

John 6:21

immediately they arrived at their destination: The immediacy was yet another of Jesus' miracles.

John 6:24

The crowd sailed north to Capernaum to search for Jesus because he had made Capernaum his home in Galilee ([Mark 2:1](#)).

John 6:26

The crowd, which had concluded that Jesus was a prophet and wanted to take advantage of him politically (see [6:15](#)), failed to see the meaning of the miracle, which Jesus then explained ([6:27-59](#)).

John 6:26-59

This dialogue took place in the synagogue at Capernaum ([6:59](#)) shortly before Passover ([6:4](#)), when Jews read the account of the exodus from Egypt (see [Exod 1-15](#)).

John 6:27

Jesus' most profound gift was not physical bread, but eternal life, which the Father authorized him to give. Physical bread is perishable; the gift of Jesus, who is himself the bread of life ([6:35](#)), will last forever.

John 6:30

The crowd demanded a miraculous sign to demonstrate Jesus' status as Messiah. Jews believed that when the Messiah appeared, he would duplicate the great miracle of Moses. Manna would once again fall, and everyone would consider it a second exodus.

John 6:32–33

Jesus corrected the people's argument: God, not Moses, fed Israel in the wilderness. The most important quest is to find and consume the true bread of God, who gives eternal life.

John 6:34

Sir, . . . give us that bread: This request parallels the request of the Samaritan woman ([4:15](#)). Spiritual awakening begins with a request for God's gift.

John 6:35

Jesus' I am statements in John depict Jesus' identity and ministry (see also [4:26](#); [8:12](#); [9:5](#); [10:7–9](#), [11–14](#); [11:25](#); [14:6](#); [15:1–5](#)). Jesus purposefully used a phrase that would make his listeners think of the Old Testament name for God ([Exod 3:14](#)). • I am the bread of life: Jesus is the true manna that descended from God ([John 6:38](#)). He satisfies the spiritual hunger of those who believe in him (cp. [4:10–13](#)).

John 6:37

those the Father has given: God moves in people's hearts, bringing them to Jesus.

John 6:37–40

Jesus' mission in the world is sure to succeed. God sent Jesus ([6:38](#)) and calls people to follow him ([6:37](#), [44](#)). Those who come to him are secure in Jesus' promise that he will not reject them or lose them ([6:39](#)).

John 6:41–42

When Jesus identified himself as the true bread . . . from heaven, the crowd faced a decision. • Isn't this . . . the son of Joseph? They stumbled because their familiarity with Jesus made his claims seem outlandish.

John 6:43–51

Stop complaining: Rather than defending himself against their complaint ([6:42](#)), Jesus turns to the problem of their spiritual receptivity. Those who love the Father and listen to him will believe in Jesus.

John 6:49–50

Jesus connected the manna of the Exodus with himself, then pointed out a major difference: The Israelites remained mortal and they all died, whereas the bread from heaven (Jesus himself) provides eternal life ([6:47](#), [51](#), [58](#)).

John 6:51

this bread . . . is my flesh: The gift that brings life is now unveiled. On the cross, Jesus offered his flesh for the life of the world.

John 6:53–58

eat the flesh . . . drink his blood: Jesus answered the question the people asked ([6:52](#)). His words hinted at the Lord's Supper yet to come (see [Luke 22:19](#)). Since "flesh and blood" was a Jewish idiom for the whole person, Jesus might have been calling people to consume him fully by completely believing in him. Some Christian traditions see the bread as Christ's literal flesh broken for us and the wine as his literal blood poured out for us. Others take the meaning in purely spiritual terms. Either way, receiving communion means no less than embracing Jesus' life-giving sacrifice.

John 6:60–61

Jesus' language ([6:53–58](#)) was shocking, offensive (see [Gen 9:4–5](#)), and hard to understand for his

disciples, just as it was to the crowd. Were they to take him literally? How would they eat his flesh? Jesus' answer is in [John 6:63](#).

John 6:63

The essence of Jesus' gift is found in the Holy Spirit alone, not in human effort (literally *the flesh*). Life and understanding come through the gift of the Spirit (see [14:15-20](#); [20:21-22](#)). True life can be found only when the Holy Spirit infuses human life.

John 6:65

people can't come to me unless the Father gives them to me (see [6:44](#)): Only God's light can penetrate the profound darkness of the world.

John 6:68-69

Simon Peter often served as spokesman for the Twelve (see also [Matt 14:28-29](#); [16:16](#); [17:4](#); [18:21](#); [19:27](#); [26:33-35](#)).

John 6:70-71

Once again Jesus demonstrated supernatural knowledge (see [1:47-49](#); [4:16-19](#)). Judas would work for evil and betray Jesus to the authorities ([12:4](#); [13:2](#); [Matt 26:14-16](#)). • Iscariot means "man from Kerioth," the home village of Judas's family.

John 7:1-52

This chapter is another account of Jesus during a Jewish festival, the Festival of Shelters. Jesus used elements of the festival to reveal his true identity to his Jewish compatriots and to show that he had fulfilled the festival's essential meaning (see [7:37-39](#); [8:12](#)).

John 7:2

Jewish men were required to come to the Temple for the Festival of Shelters ([Exod 23:14-17](#); [Deut 16:16](#)), an annual seven-day autumn harvest festival in Jerusalem six months after Passover

([John 6:4](#)). People lived in temporary shelters for the seven days as a reminder of the tents Israel used for forty years in the wilderness.

John 7:3-5

Jesus' brothers (see also [Mark 3:31](#)) reminded him of his religious obligation to celebrate the festival. Their words were cynical because at this time they didn't believe in him ([John 7:5](#)).

John 7:6-8

Jesus said that it was not the right time for him to go publicly to Jerusalem, although he later went secretly ([7:10](#); cp. study note on [12:23](#)).

John 7:15

The leaders wanted Jesus to show his credentials. Jesus had not been trained under a rabbi but was taught by his heavenly Father (cp. Peter and John, [Acts 4:13](#); contrast Paul, [Acts 22:3](#)).

John 7:17

Those who truly want to do the will of God receive and accept Jesus and his teaching (see also [5:42-47](#)). Those who focus on the world, by contrast, are not receptive to Christ.

John 7:19

Moses gave you the law, but none of you obeys it! The Jewish leaders were proud of the law of Moses, but ironically, in trying to kill Jesus, they were breaking the law ([Exod 20:13](#)).

John 7:20

You're demon possessed! See [8:48-52](#); [10:20-21](#).

John 7:22

The law required circumcision on the eighth day ([Lev 12:3](#)) and permitted a boy to be circumcised

even if that day fell on the Sabbath. Jesus argued as a rabbi would, from “the lesser to the greater,” using circumcision as a precedent for healing, both of which are religious works.

John 7:27

Some of the crowd thought that since they could trace Jesus’ earthly origins, he could not be the Messiah. They believed that the Messiah would simply appear.

John 7:29

I come from him: Jesus sidestepped the speculation (7:27, 40–44) about his earthly origins and focused on his heavenly origins. His astounding claim provoked the religious leaders to try to arrest him for blasphemy (7:30; cp. 10:30–33).

John 7:30

Jesus’ opponents failed to arrest him because in God’s sovereign plan, his time, when he would be glorified on the cross, had not yet come (see study note on 12:23; see also 10:17–18; 18:6–8). All four arrest scenes in 7:1–8:59 stress that Jesus was in control, not the Jewish leaders.

John 7:32–36

Jesus announced his return to the one who sent him, the Father in heaven (17:1–7). However, the Pharisees misunderstood, thinking he was leaving Judea to go among Gentiles (whom Pharisees would never visit). • The leaders would not find Jesus after his ascension. • you cannot go where I am going: These Pharisees, still in darkness, could not enter heaven, so Jesus would be beyond their reach there.

John 7:37–38

living water: See 4:10–14. A water ceremony was held each day during the Festival of Shelters, with prayer for God to send rain in the late autumn. The final day, called “the great day,” was the climax of the festival, when the ceremony was repeated seven times. Water was poured over the altar as

Levites sang [Isa 12:3](#) (see [Zech 14:8](#); see also *Mishnah Sukkah* ch 4). • Anyone who is thirsty may come to me! Jesus fulfilled an essential element in the Festival of Shelters. He himself is the source of living water, available to anyone who believes.

John 7:39

In Jesus’ crucifixion and resurrection, his life and the Spirit were poured out (see [19:34](#); [20:22](#)).

John 7:41–42

These Jews, different from the crowd ([7:25–27](#)) who thought the Messiah would appear mysteriously, believed the prophecy that the Messiah would be from Bethlehem of Judea (see [Mic 5:2](#)). However, they stumbled over the fact that Jesus seemed to be from Galilee, where he grew up.

John 7:45–52

The story concludes with the Jewish leaders frustrated and the world divided over Jesus (cp. [7:25–27](#), [31–32](#)). • guards returned: See [7:32](#).

John 7:49–51

Nicodemus was probably in the process of coming to faith (see [3:1–21](#); [19:38–42](#)). Contrary to the implication of [7:48](#), some of the Pharisees—not just the ignorant crowd—believed in Jesus.

John 7:52

no prophet ever comes from Galilee! The Jewish leaders were apparently unaware that Jesus had been born in Bethlehem of Judea, not in Galilee (see [Matt 2:1](#); [Luke 2:1–7](#)).

John 7:53–8.11

This story, a later addition to the Gospel of John, does not appear in the earliest Greek manuscripts. However, it is likely an authentic story from Jesus’ life.

John 8:3

The teachers of religious law were Jewish scholars who specialized in knowing the Old Testament law and the oral traditions that interpreted the law.

John 8:4

The form of the Greek sentence emphasizes the legal claim against the woman. She had been caught while committing the sin of adultery. The law required two witnesses and carefully outlined what evidence was needed.

John 8:5

The requirement of the law . . . to stone her indicates that the woman was engaged or married ([Lev 20:10](#); [Deut 22:23-24](#)). The law also stated that her lover should be killed with her, but these religious leaders apparently ignored their obligation to that part of the statute. • These men could have dealt with the woman privately and kept her from public shame, but Jesus was their real target as they demanded, What do you say? Would he neglect the law since he had a reputation for mercy? Or would he ignore the woman's tragedy?

John 8:6

It is impossible to know what Jesus . . . wrote in the dust. It has been suggested that he wrote the sins of the accusers.

John 8:7

Jesus' answer did not mean that an accuser had to be morally perfect to make legal accusations. His reference to the one who has never sinned points to the motives of the accusers.

John 8:9

The jury crumbled as they slipped away. One accuser departed, followed by another, and then a succession of bystanders.

John 8:11

Neither do I: Jesus' words of assurance did not suggest that the woman was innocent. Jesus views sin and judgment seriously, yet he looks graciously and forgivingly on those caught in sin's grip.

John 8:12

During the Festival of Shelters, sixteen gold bowls in the inner courts of the Temple were filled with oil and lighted. Jesus stood beneath these lights in the Temple ([8:20](#)) and said that he was now the source of the light. Jesus' light brings salvation not only to Israel but to the world, regardless of race or locale.

John 8:12-59

The debate about whether or not Jesus is the Messiah continues from [7:52](#). Jesus was still at the Festival of Shelters in Jerusalem. During the festival, the conflicts Jesus had endured in ch [7](#) continued and intensified.

John 8:13

The Pharisees charged that Jesus' claims were not valid because Jewish law ([Deut 19:15](#)) requires more than one witness (cp. [John 5:31-32](#); see [8:17](#)).

John 8:14-15

Jesus answered the Pharisees' charges, saying that he could make such claims about himself because he knew both his origin (heaven) and his destination (heaven). He then pointed to the most vital witness for his case, his Father who sent him ([8:16](#)).

John 8:19

Throughout the festival, Jesus' audience proved they were in the darkness as they misunderstood him. They wanted to meet Jesus' father, who is God. Since they did not truly know God, they were unable to understand Jesus.

John 8:20

The Treasury was located in the section of the Temple called the Court of the Women. Jesus often taught there so that both men and women could hear him ([Mark 12:41](#)). • his time: See notes on [John 2:4](#); [12:23](#).

John 8:21

In the earlier debate at the festival, Jesus' origins were at issue ([7:27](#)). Here, Jesus mentioned going away to the place he came from, meaning heaven. However, once again, his words were misunderstood.

John 8:23

Jesus' listeners were from below; they could not comprehend Jesus' meaning because he was from above ([3:31](#); see study note on 3:3).

John 8:24

unless you believe that I Am who I claim to be: Jesus used God's divine name (see [4:26](#); [Exod 3:14](#)), but the listeners missed the nuance ([John 8:25](#)). • die in your sins: Jesus' presence in the world, as the light penetrating the darkness, is the world's only chance for salvation.

John 8:25

Who are you? Later they understood and tried to stone Jesus for blasphemy ([8:59](#)).

John 8:28

The synoptic Gospels describe Jesus as predicting his death three times (e.g., [Mark 8:31](#); [9:31](#); [10:33-34](#)). John parallels this ([John 3:14](#); [8:28](#); [12:33-34](#)), showing that the Father governs his Son's fate.

John 8:30

Once again, the festival audience was divided. Earlier, the debate concluded with plans to arrest Jesus ([8:20](#)). Now many . . . believed in him, convinced that he was telling the truth. However, once Jesus' full identity was disclosed their faith was sorely challenged ([8:31-59](#)).

John 8:31-32

Discipleship is more than knowing who Jesus is. It is also about obeying his teachings ([3:36](#); [14:15](#), [21](#), [23](#); [15:10](#)). • Because Jesus is the truth ([14:6](#)), knowing him brings discernment of what is true and what is false. • set you free: The truth brings freedom from darkness, falsehood, and sin.

John 8:33

Jesus challenged a widely held assumption about Israel's status as God's chosen people. Their heritage as descendants of Abraham had inspired feelings of privilege and immunity rather than obligation and responsibility (cp. [Amos 3:1-15](#)). • The people misunderstood what it meant to be set free. Jesus was not referring to freedom from human slavery; he meant release from spiritual bondage to sin ([John 8:34](#)). Truth, not their religious heritage, would free them ([8:32](#); [Rom 6:17](#); [8:2](#); [1 Jn 3:4](#), [8](#), [9](#)).

John 8:35

Jesus unfolded the logic of his argument: If Israel is a spiritual slave, it has the same insecurity as any slave in a household. Members of a family are secure, slaves are not. Only Jesus can change the status of those in spiritual slavery and make them free and secure.

John 8:37-41

The leaders' plot to kill Jesus ([5:18](#)) unmasked their true identity. They belonged to a different household, and their father was not Jesus' Father. They were relying on the fact that their ancestral father was Abraham, but Jesus challenged their spiritual pedigree. The climax of his challenge comes in [8:44](#).

John 8:41

your real father: Jesus knew who controlled them.

- We aren't illegitimate children! This was both a defense and an attack. In Greek, the pronoun *we* is emphatic: "*We* [in contrast to *you*] are not illegitimate," implying that Jesus was illegitimate (see [Matt 1:18-25](#)).

John 8:44

Since the unbelieving people did not love Jesus ([8:42](#); [1 In 5:1](#)), they were not children of the Father in heaven who sent his beloved Son ([John 8:47](#)). Their true spiritual ancestry was revealed in their desire to kill God's Son. This was the work of the devil, who brought death to the world (see [Gen 3:1-20](#); [Rom 5:12-14](#)).

John 8:48-49

By calling Jesus a Samaritan devil, his opponents turned his charges back on him with a racial slur (see study note on 4:4-6). Their statement that Jesus was demon-possessed (also [7:20](#); [8:52](#); [10:20](#)) countered his claim that they were linked to Satan ([8:44](#)). Jesus rightly replied that these words were a profound dishonor. In fact, it was a serious and unforgivable offense ([Mark 3:22-29](#)).

John 8:53

Who do you think you are? This question was antagonistic and aggressive. However, if Jesus is immortal, ruling over life and death, then he is greater than Abraham, the prophets, or any of the greatest people in Israel's history ([8:58](#)).

John 8:56

Like his opponents, Jesus appealed to Abraham. Rabbis taught that God had given Abraham prophetic insight, teaching him about the coming age of the Messiah.

John 8:57

You aren't even fifty years old: The Jewish leaders misunderstood Jesus: He was talking about his divine pre-existence, not his physical age.

John 8:58

before Abraham was even born, I Am! Jesus' life spans the past from before creation ([1:1-2](#)) and sweeps beyond the present into eternity. • I Am: This title is reminiscent of God's name given on Mount Sinai ([Exod 3:14](#); cp. [John 4:26](#); [Isa 43:11-13](#); [48:12](#)).

John 8:59

Jesus' audience finally understood his claim to divinity ([8:58](#)), and they were furious. They believed they had heard blasphemy and picked up stones to throw at him, which was the proper legal response ([Lev 24:16](#)). • Jesus was hidden from them because God had appointed a different time for his death (see study note on John 12:23; see also [7:30](#), [44](#); [Luke 4:29-30](#)).

John 9:1-41

At the Festival of Shelters (chs [7-8](#)), Jesus claimed to be the light of the world ([8:12](#)). Now John tells about Jesus giving light, both physically and spiritually, to a blind man who lived in darkness (see [9:5](#)). The story ends with a splendid reversal of roles: The blind man who was assumed to be in spiritual darkness could see God's light, whereas the Pharisees, who could see physically and were thought to be enlightened, were shown to be spiritually blind.

John 9:2

The disciples assumed that someone's sin—the man's or his parents'—had caused him to be born blind. Jesus corrected this common belief ([9:3](#)).

John 9:5

I am the light of the world: See study note on 8:12.

John 9:6

During the New Testament era, saliva was used for medical purposes (see [Mark 7:32–35](#); [8:22–25](#)).

John 9:7

Siloam, a pool at the south end of the city of Jerusalem, was the source of water for the ceremonies at the Festival of Shelters. • Siloam means “sent”: This phrase contained a double meaning: Jesus, who has been sent by God ([4:34](#); [5:23](#), [37](#); [7:28](#); [8:26](#); [12:44](#); [14:24](#)), told the blind man to wash in the pool called “sent.”

John 9:11

The blind man identified Jesus and testified strongly about him. The man was healed of his physical infirmity, gained increasing spiritual insight ([9:17](#), [33](#)), and became Jesus’ disciple ([9:38](#); cp. [5:11–15](#)).

John 9:13

The Pharisees (see [1:24](#)) were arbiters of legal interpretation, so the community looked to them to explain this miracle. Rather than celebrate the healing, these religious leaders interrogated the man because Jesus had performed the miracle on the Sabbath (see [5:16–18](#)).

John 9:17

The man had already identified his healer ([9:11](#), [16](#)). Now he made his own spiritual judgment, calling Jesus a prophet.

John 9:18

The Pharisees wanted to discount the miracle and hoped the man’s parents would deny the healing.

John 9:20–22

His parents confirmed that their son had been born blind, but they hesitated to judge how he could see because they were afraid of the social consequences.

John 9:24

God should get the glory for this: Greek reads *Give glory to God*. Cp. [Josh 7:19](#).

John 9:28–29

The Pharisees could not defeat the logic of the miraculous sign ([9:24–25](#), [30–33](#)), so they turned from reason and cursed him (see [9:34](#)). • The harsh division between Jesus and the religious leaders was clear. They considered those who followed Jesus to have rejected Moses and Judaism.

John 9:30

The Jewish leaders did not know where Jesus came from. The man’s astonishment was understandable—a healing like this was unprecedented. Jesus’ works confirmed his origin as from God. Once his true identity was known, belief and discipleship should have followed, but the Jewish leaders were willfully blind.

John 9:32–33

Only God could do something such as open the eyes of someone born blind. By healing the man, Jesus offered the Jewish leaders an unquestionable sign that he was from God and was the Messiah (cp. [Ps 146:8](#); [Isa 35:5](#); [42:7](#)).

John 9:34

Discipline such as being thrown out of the synagogue was not uncommon. It brought social isolation that might require the man’s departure from the village. Such serious persecution was precisely what Jesus predicted for his followers ([15:18–27](#); [16:2](#)).

John 9:35

Son of Man: See [1:51](#); [3:13](#), [14](#); [5:27](#); [6:27](#), [53](#), [62](#); [8:28](#). The Greek translates a Hebrew and Aramaic phrase meaning “human being.” People were not completely sure what Jesus meant by it (see [12:34](#)). However, it signifies Jesus’ identity both as human and as the Messiah (cp. [Dan 7:13-14](#)).

John 9:35-38

Jesus pressed the man who had been blind to understand the miracle and the identity of his healer. Immediately, the man expressed faith and gave Jesus reverence due only to God ([9:38](#); cp. [20:28](#)).

John 9:40-41

Are you saying we’re blind? Jesus answered that those who claim to hold all religious truth will discover that they are blind, while those who recognize their spiritual poverty will find true sight. In the story, the blind man and his family frequently confessed that they did not know, while the Pharisees repeatedly stated their confidence and remained guilty because of their religious pride. If they had confessed their ignorance and admitted their spiritual blindness, they would be guiltless. Instead, their conscious and willful rejection of Jesus established their guilt.

John 10:1

A wilderness shepherd would build a sheepfold, a pen with low stone walls topped by thorny branches, to hold his sheep at night and protect them from danger. • The pen had one gate (or opening in the wall) that was closed with branches. Any invasion of the pen was a threat to the flock. • A bad shepherd was like a thief and a robber. He exploited the sheep for his own interests and did not care for or nurture them. Bad shepherds took the sheep’s milk and wool for themselves and butchered the sheep without providing for the animal’s safety ([Ezek 34:3](#); see [Isa 56:11](#); [Jer 23:1-4](#)). This was Jesus’ most stinging indictment of the Jewish leaders.

John 10:1-21

This illustration of a shepherd and his sheep assumes a Middle Eastern understanding of shepherding and draws on Old Testament tradition deeply embedded in first-century Jewish culture. God was the shepherd of Israel ([Gen 49:24](#); [Pss 23](#); [78:52-53](#); [Isa 40:10-11](#)). Spiritual and political leaders of Israel were also shepherds of God’s people, the flock of God ([Isa 56:9-12](#); [Jer 23:1-4](#); [Ezek 34](#)). Jesus’ sermon builds on the occasion of Hanukkah (see [John 10:22](#)) to address the theme of shepherds, using this festival as an opportunity to reflect on Israel’s leaders (“shepherds”) in light of [Ezek 34](#). Jesus presents himself as the good shepherd ([John 10:11-14](#)).

John 10:1-42

[Chapter 10](#) continues the series of festival sermons (see study note on 5:1-10:42). Here, the setting is Hanukkah (the Festival of Dedication), the timing of which is crucial to understanding the story (see study note on 10:22).

John 10:3

the sheep recognize his voice: The Middle Eastern shepherd is well known for having intimate knowledge of the sheep. Sheep are led with flute tunes, songs, or verbal commands.

John 10:4

A good shepherd always leads his sheep; he never drives them. When they recognize his voice, they trust his leadership and follow him.

John 10:7

I am: See study note on 6:35. A good shepherd is known for guarding the sheep at the gate as a sentry.

John 10:9

will be saved (or *will find safety*): As gatekeeper, Jesus keeps away those who might harm his sheep,

keeping his sheep inside the pen where they are safe.

John 10:10

Jesus' followers must be wary of bad shepherds who desire to steal and kill and destroy. As the Hanukkah story was told to the Jewish people (see study note on 10:22), they were reminded about false religious leaders whose failures had led to the loss of God's Temple in Jerusalem.

John 10:11–13

Small villages often created communal flocks and employed a hired hand to tend the sheep. However, an employee lacked the commitment of a true shepherd. The wilderness of Judea had many predators. When a wolf or other predators attacked, the hired hand would run rather than defend the sheep. Jesus will never do this; he will always stand between his sheep and danger.

John 10:11–14

I am: See study note on 6:35. The good shepherd leads his sheep, finds food and water, and locates paths in the wilderness (see [Ps 23](#)). The good shepherd stands between his sheep and danger ([John 10:11](#)) and fights to protect them. The Old Testament describes God as Israel's shepherd ([Pss 23](#); [80:1](#); [Isa 40:10–11](#)). The leaders of God's people should shepherd their flock as God does ([Ezek 34:23](#)). However, the leaders of Israel in Jesus' time were bad shepherds.

John 10:14–17

I sacrifice my life for the sheep: Jesus was alluding to his crucifixion (ch [19](#)).

John 10:15

The Father and the Son share a profound intimacy, which Jesus shares with his sheep through the Holy Spirit ([14:23–31](#); [15:1–11](#)).

John 10:16

other sheep: Believers outside Judaism would one day join Jesus' sheepfold (see [11:52](#)). In Jesus' vision for his people, Jewish and Gentile believers from diverse cultures would become one flock with one shepherd ([17:20–23](#)).

John 10:18

No one can take my life from me: The Son's death was voluntary. Jesus was not a martyr or a victim. His decision to die was freely given in obedience and intimate relationship with his Father (see [Acts 2:23–24](#)). • Jesus' resurrection was not an afterthought in which God rescued his Son from tragedy. God could not be contained by a tomb, and since Jesus and the Father are one, Jesus possessed the authority to rise from death.

John 10:19–21

Jesus divided his audience yet again (see also [6:66–69](#); [7:43](#); [9:16](#)), inspiring either opposition or faith. • He's demon possessed: Cp. [7:20](#); [8:48–49](#), [52](#).

John 10:22

Hanukkah was a winter festival that commemorated the rededication of the Temple after it had been defiled by Antiochus IV (175–163 BC). Two hundred years before Christ, Greek soldiers captured and pillaged the Jerusalem Temple, took its treasures and artifacts, and made it unusable for worship. In the winter of 165–164 BC, a Jewish army led by Judas Maccabeus reclaimed the Temple and rededicated it to the Lord. The Festival of Hanukkah ("dedication") marked this dedication (see *1 Maccabees* 3–4; *2 Maccabees* 8:1–10:8). During the festival, priests examined their commitment to service, using [Ezek 34](#) as their principal text for reflection (also [Jer 23:1–4](#); [25:32–38](#); [Zech 11](#)). At this Hanukkah celebration, Jesus used the shepherd theme from [Ezek 34](#) to distinguish between himself as the good shepherd ([John 10:11](#)) and Israel's current religious leaders as bad shepherds ([10:10](#), [12–13](#)).

John 10:23

Massive covered colonnades surrounded the four sides of the central courtyard of the Temple. Solomon's Colonnade, on the east, provided shelter from winter weather.

John 10:24

The people who surrounded Jesus might have been seeking clarity, or they might have been hostile. In [Luke 21:20](#) and [Heb 11:30](#), the same word describes how Jerusalem and Jericho were surrounded before being destroyed; in [Acts 14:20](#) it refers to Paul's disciples rallying around him after he was injured.

John 10:25

Jesus had already provided the Jewish people and their religious leaders with sufficient proof that he is the Son of God. The problem was not lack of information, but their unwillingness to believe him.

John 10:25–42

In Jesus' final public presentation of evidence about himself in this Gospel, he gives an exhaustive statement of his identity ([10:30](#)).

John 10:27–29

As the good shepherd, Jesus would die for his sheep and secure them from all predators and thieves ([10:1](#), [8](#), [11](#); cp. [Ezek 34:22–23](#)). • The power of the Father, appearing in Christ, keeps his sheep safe. Believers cannot be taken from Jesus because no one is more powerful than he is. Their security is not sustained by their own efforts, but by Christ. • The word translated snatch implies violence (as in [John 6:15](#)).

John 10:30

The Father and the Son are two separate persons with one purpose and nature ([1:1](#), [14](#); [14:9](#); [20:28](#)). This is the basis of Jesus' power to protect God's flock ([10:28–29](#)) and a stunning expression of Jesus' divinity.

John 10:31–33

The people realized Jesus' meaning (see [10:33](#)) and wanted to kill him. The problem was not Jesus' good works, but his claim to divinity (see [6:42](#), [60](#); [7:29–30](#)). Committing blasphemy was punishable by stoning ([Lev 24:23](#); see [John 8:59](#)).

John 10:34–36

I say, you are gods! If the word *god* could be applied to people other than the Lord, then Jesus was not breaking the law by referring to himself in this way. Yet Jesus is not just any son of God; he is the Son of God who was sent . . . into the world.

John 10:38

Jesus' miraculous works should help true believers know and understand that the full reality of God dwells in Jesus.

John 10:40

His revelation to the Jewish leaders now complete, Jesus retired to the region beyond the Jordan River where John the Baptist had once worked and where Jesus was baptized.

John 10:41

everything he said about this man has come true: See [1:19–51](#); [3:22–36](#). The fulfillment of John the Baptist's predictions confirms both that he was a prophet and that what he said about Jesus was true.

John 10:42

This is a note of irony. While Jesus found little faith among the religious leaders in the holy city of Jerusalem, in the desert he found many who . . . believed.

John 11:1

In Hebrew, Lazarus is a shortened form of *Eleazar* (“God helps”). Among Jews in the first century, it was the fourth-most-common name for a man (see also [Luke 16:19–31](#)). • Bethany was a small village east of Jerusalem just over the Mount of Olives ([John 11:18](#)) and was where Jesus often stayed when he was in Jerusalem. Jesus would have traveled through Bethany on the way to Jerusalem because most Jews coming from Galilee used a route going south to Jericho, then west to Jerusalem. • Mary and Martha were sisters ([Luke 10:38–42](#)). Martha was probably older; she was the host in Luke’s story and here represented the family. Mary later anointed Jesus with perfume ([John 12:1–8](#)).

John 11:1–57

The raising of Lazarus foreshadows Jesus’ own coming death and resurrection. Even the description of Lazarus’ grave ([11:38](#), [44](#)) prefigures Jesus’ grave ([20:1](#), [7](#)). Shortly after this event, Jesus was anointed for burial ([12:3](#)) and the hour of his glorification began ([12:23](#)).

John 11:3

The two sisters had a dilemma. They knew Jesus’ power as a healer, but they also realized that his return to Judea would entail personal risk ([11:8](#)).

John 11:4

Jesus’ response paralleled his words about the man born blind ([9:1–5](#)). Jesus already knew that Lazarus was dead ([11:14](#)); he was talking about Lazarus’ resurrection ([11:43](#)), which would bring glory to God.

John 11:6

The trip from where Jesus was staying (see [10:40](#)) to Bethany would have taken only one day, but Jesus followed his own sense of timing ([2:4](#); [7:5–9](#)) and would not be compelled by others.

John 11:8

The disciples were rightly worried about the risk (see [7:25](#); [8:37](#), [44](#), [59](#); [10:31](#), [39](#)).

John 11:16

Thomas: See also [14:5](#); [20:24](#); [21:2](#); [Mark 3:18](#). • Let’s go, too—and die: Thomas knew that previous visits to Judea had been dangerous ([John 5:18](#); [10:31](#), [39](#)). Traveling to Jerusalem now would probably mean death for Jesus (cp. [11:49–50](#)).

John 11:17

People were buried on the same day as their death. John noted that Lazarus had been in his grave for four days, so the miracle could not be construed as resuscitation.

John 11:19

Life in New Testament times was lived publicly. Lazarus’s large extended family, as well as the villagers, had arrived for a seven-day mourning period. To console the sisters in their loss, there was great wailing and crying (see [11:33](#) and corresponding study note).

John 11:21

Lord, if only you had been here: Mary later repeated Martha’s words ([11:32](#)), because both sisters knew Jesus’ reputation as a healer. They concluded that Jesus would have healed Lazarus, but they did not imagine that Jesus would restore him from death.

John 11:22

whatever you ask: Martha thought that Jesus could still intervene in some way. Despite this, she objected when Jesus wanted to open the tomb ([11:39](#)); she wasn’t thinking that Jesus would raise her brother from the dead.

John 11:24

when everyone else rises, at the last day: Martha misunderstood (cp. [11:11–13](#)), thinking that Jesus was referring to the general resurrection of the dead at the end of time.

John 11:25

Jesus helped Martha to believe in him not simply as a healer, but as one who vanquishes death. • I am the resurrection and the life: Victory over death is an aspect of living in association with Jesus. Although his followers are still mortal, they will enjoy eternal life after death. Regarding Jesus' *I am* statements, see the study note on 6:35.

John 11:26–27

Do you believe this? Jesus was not asking if Martha believed he could bring Lazarus from the grave. Rather, did she believe that life itself is linked to Jesus? • “Yes, Lord”: Even though the full implications were beyond her comprehension, she acknowledged that Jesus was indeed the Messiah. Yet she was surprised at the power he held.

John 11:28–32

Mary now joined the scene on the edge of the village, repeating her sister's plaintive cry. She fell at Jesus' feet, not in worship but in desperate grief.

John 11:33

The loud weeping and wailing typified public displays of grief in this culture ([Mark 5:38](#)), as did beating one's chest ([Luke 18:13](#)). • The Greek word translated deep anger expresses human outrage, fury, and anger. Jesus was furious, not at Martha or Mary, but at the futility of this scene and the people's unbelief in light of the reality of the resurrection.

John 11:39

Lazarus was buried in a tomb cut from the rocky hillside; such tombs were common. The tomb was closed and opened for further burials with a rolling

stone that covered the entrance. A central door led to a cave room where burial benches were carved in stone along the inner wall. Horizontal burial chambers were cut along the top edge of the benches.

John 11:45–46

As news of the miracle spread rapidly into the city of Jerusalem ([12:9](#), [17](#)), public opinion was again divided ([6:66–69](#); [7:43](#); [9:16](#); [10:19](#); [11:37](#)). Jesus' reputation as a healer and as one who could raise the dead was known in Galilee (see [Matt 9:24–26](#); [10:8](#); [11:5](#)). Now he had brought this power to Judea.

John 11:48

The council's deliberations unveiled their fears that everyone would believe in him. If people believed that the Messiah had come, the political implications would be threatening. The Romans viewed Jewish messiahs with suspicion, and the movement surrounding Jesus might inspire them to invade and destroy Jerusalem and its Temple.

John 11:49

Caiaphas was the ruler of the high council from AD 18–36. He worked for ten years alongside Pontius Pilate, governor of Judea (AD 26–36; see [18:29](#)), keeping the peace with Rome.

John 11:50–51

it's better . . . that one man should die: Caiaphas's words were ironic. He meant that it was better for a revolutionary to die than to have the Romans crush the entire Jewish nation. But Caiaphas was correct in a way that he could not perceive. The salvation that Judaism needed had little to do with Rome; it would come through the cross of Christ. John notes that Caiaphas's inspiration was not his own but came from God.

John 11:52

Christ's death was not for Israel only, but for all, including people of other cultures scattered around the world ([10:16](#); [12:32](#)).

John 11:53-54

When the Jewish leaders began to plot Jesus' death, Jesus made a judicious political move in response ([11:54](#)). • Ephraim was a village about twelve miles north of Jerusalem, where Jesus was safe from the Sanhedrin but close enough to walk to the upcoming Passover festival ([11:55](#)).

John 11:55-57

As crowds arrived in Jerusalem on pilgrimage for Passover (see [2:13](#)), the city was buzzing with talk about Jesus and his miracle of raising Lazarus from the dead. People wondered if Jesus would be obedient to the law and come to the city to celebrate or play it safe in the countryside. The priests and Pharisees knew that Jesus was faithful to the law and would attend the festival, so they tried to make the city a trap for him.

John 12:1

Pilgrims from throughout Israel began arriving in Jerusalem the week before the Passover. The festival was on Thursday that year; Jesus arrived late the preceding Friday, just before the Sabbath.

John 12:1-50

Two stories build simultaneously. A growing number of people are praising Jesus (this climaxes in [12:12-13](#)), and the authorities are increasingly determined to arrest him and put him to death. • John records three events that occurred just days prior to Passover ([12:1-11](#), [12-19](#), [20-36](#)). Then he explains why most of the people refused to believe and details Jesus' final public appeal ([12:37-50](#)).

John 12:2

who ate: Or *who reclined*. The typical posture for eating was to recline at a low table.

John 12:3

Mary . . . anointed Jesus' feet: Doing so was not awkward, because Jews reclined at formal meals, but it was certainly a dramatic gesture (cp. [Matt 26:6-16](#); [Mark 14:3-9](#)). • Nard, a precious spice imported from North India, was sweet, red, and smelled like gladiola perfume. Twelve ounces of nard cost a year's wages ([John 12:5](#)). According to Mark, Mary also anointed Jesus' head ([Mark 14:3](#)), and the perfume ran down and scented his garments ([Mark 14:8](#)). • her hair: Women never unveiled their hair in public (see [Luke 7:38](#)). Mary was acting with extravagant abandon and devotion.

John 12:5

a year's wages: Judas may have been exaggerating, but Mary's sacrifice was certainly very costly.

John 12:7

Leave her alone: Jesus' defense of Mary interpreted her deed. The nard was a burial spice for his death. Jesus was readied for burial as he moved toward the hour of glorification and death (see study note on [12:23](#)).

John 12:8

Jesus would never neglect the poor, but this opportunity to serve him was unparalleled.

John 12:12

The next day was Sunday (see [12:1](#)). • A large crowd of pilgrims (many from Galilee) camped in this region. As Jesus followed the road to Jerusalem, they cheered him. This triumphal entry appears in all four Gospels ([Matt 21:1-11](#); [Mark 11:1-11](#); [Luke 19:29-38](#)).

John 12:13

palm branches: The date palm was a celebratory symbol of Jewish nationalism. • meet him: The Greek word commonly describes crowds greeting a returning, triumphant king. • Blessings on the one: The crowd quoted [Ps 118:25-26](#), with a greeting for those who came to Jerusalem. The phrase Hail to the King of Israel is not in the psalm (but see [Zeph 3:15](#)). Although the people saw Jesus as a national political liberator, he rejected this role ([John 6:15](#)).

John 12:14

By choosing a young donkey rather than a warhorse, Jesus calmed the frenzied crowd that was passionate for his kingship. He also fulfilled Old Testament predictions regarding the Messiah (see [Zech 9:9](#)) and showed that his kingship was not that of a warrior. His gift is life, not conquest.

John 12:16

The crowds and even the disciples didn't understand Jesus' true significance. When the disciples received the Holy Spirit following Jesus' glorification, they fully comprehended who Jesus was (see [2:22](#)).

John 12:17-19

This scene describes the apex of Jesus' popularity.

John 12:19

everyone: Literally *the world*. The Pharisees' words were more significant than they realized. Jesus came to reach the world ([3:17](#)), and the Pharisees said that Jesus had accomplished his task.

John 12:20

Among the people drawn to Jesus ([12:19](#)) were some Greeks, God-fearing Gentiles who had come to Passover to worship. Jesus' mission was not simply to Israel but encompassed the entire world ([10:16](#); [11:52](#)). Following Jesus' resurrection, the church's mission was to go beyond Judea to

Samaria, and ultimately to the ends of the earth ([Matt 28:19](#); [Acts 1:8](#)).

John 12:21

The Greeks approached Philip because he had a Greek name and was no doubt Greek.

John 12:23

Jesus often said that the time (literally *the hour*) had not yet come ([2:4](#); [7:30](#); [8:20](#)), but now it had. The coming of the Greeks also marked the beginning of the key moment in Jesus' ministry—the time of his glorification. This occurred when Jesus' sacrificial work on the cross was completed ([19:30](#)), he rose from the dead ([20:1-31](#)), he gave the Spirit ([20:22](#)), and he returned to his place of glory in heaven ([17:5](#), [11](#)). The connection with the Greeks who had come to Jerusalem ([12:20](#)) was significant: Jesus' ministry among the Jews alone was finished and he now belonged to the wider world.

John 12:24

The central event of Jesus' glorification ([12:23](#)) was the cross. As with a kernel . . . planted in the soil, Jesus' death would bring abundant life.

John 12:25

For disciples, sacrifice and self-effacement are means of gaining the fullness of life provided by Jesus' sacrifice. Those who renounce the world will join Jesus in eternity and be honored by God just as Jesus is.

John 12:27

my soul is deeply troubled: John used the same term (Greek *tarassō*) to describe Jesus' strong emotion of agony before Lazarus' tomb ([11:33](#); also [13:21](#)). When Jesus stood before death, he could not be impassive. Jesus experienced genuine anguish, yet he remained strong in obedience to the Father's will ([5:19-23](#); [6:37](#); [8:29](#), [38](#); [14:31](#)).

John 12:28

a voice spoke from heaven: Cp. [Matt 3:17](#); [17:5](#); [Mark 1:11](#); [9:7](#); [Luke 3:22](#); [9:35](#). • God had already brought glory to himself when Christ entered the world ([John 1:14](#)) and through Jesus' work, which showed God's power to the world. • I will do so again: The final display of glory would come at the cross (see [12:23](#); [17:1](#)). In John, the cross is an event of glory as Christ was "lifted up" ([12:32](#)) and glorified there. Jesus was prepared for crucifixion like a king coming to his coronation; the cross was like a throne (see [19:19-22](#)), and he was buried like royalty. Jesus' time of glorification included the entire sequence from arrest through resurrection.

John 12:29

It was impossible for people to comprehend what was happening with Jesus, and many of his signs led to confusion and division in the crowd. Only later did his disciples understand ([2:22](#); [12:16](#)), when Jesus was glorified and the Spirit was given. Still, God's voice symbolized his validation of his Son before the world.

John 12:31-33

The time for judging does not occur only on Judgment Day; it began when the light penetrated the darkness and unmasked it ([3:19](#); [5:24](#); [9:39](#)). • Satan, the ruler of this world, is the architect of darkness, corrupter of the world, and promoter of death. Although Satan's final demise lies in the future, the work of Christ unraveled Satan's domain (see [Luke 10:17-18](#); [Mark 3:27](#)). Christ is now enthroned as ruler in heaven ([Acts 7:55-56](#); [Eph 1:19-22](#)).

John 12:32-34

when I am lifted up from the earth (see [3:14](#); [8:28](#)): The crowd did not understand what Jesus meant. The Greek verb refers to being exalted ([Matt 23:12](#)) or honored ([Luke 10:15](#)). In John, the cross was not a place of shame and disgrace for Jesus, but the place where Jesus' true glory was shown.

John 12:34

Popular Judaism believed that the Messiah would live forever and triumph over his foes. Jesus' point of view seemed incomprehensible. • who is this Son of Man, anyway? The Jews did not understand what sort of Messiah planned to die.

John 12:36

Jesus was the light ([1:4](#), [7-9](#); [3:19-21](#); [8:12](#)), and he urged the crowd to quickly make the choice to believe in him before it was too late. • They had the choice of becoming children of the light by rebirth through the power of God ([1:12-13](#)). • Jesus... was hidden from them: Jesus withdrew first from Judea ([11:54](#)) and then from this audience ([12:36](#)), and soon he would withdraw from the world ([17:11](#)).

John 12:37

Jesus' work was finished, yet most of the people... did not believe in him. His sermons before the world were complete and the signs had been displayed, but he was rejected ([1:11](#)).

John 12:39-40

The people couldn't believe: John quotes [Isa 6:10](#) to explain Israel's unbelief (see [Matt 13:13-15](#); [Mark 4:12](#); [Luke 8:10](#); [Acts 28:26-27](#)). When revelation comes, we must believe. If we refuse, the light disappears ([John 12:35-36](#)). When God's light departs from the world, the darkness closes over unbelieving hearts.

John 12:41

Isaiah had glimpsed the Messiah's glory and how the world would respond (see [Isa 6:10](#)).

John 12:42-43

Many people did believe in him, but they wouldn't admit it. To follow Jesus involves telling others about him despite the social consequences ([1:35-51](#); [4:1-42](#)).

John 12:44–50

Jesus makes a final appeal for belief. These verses summarize chs [1–12](#). Jesus was sent by the Father, the sole source of his ministry. Jesus is the light shining in darkness to bring salvation and eternal life to all who believe in him.

John 12:49–50

The greatest error is for people to see the light and reject it, thinking it has no connection with the Father who sent the light.

John 13:1–38

The setting is Jesus' final Passover meal on Thursday evening, when Judas Iscariot betrays Jesus. John does not record the meal itself as the synoptic Gospels do ([Matt 26:17–29](#); [Mark 14:12–25](#); [Luke 22:7–20](#); see also [1 Cor 11:23–26](#)). John emphasizes other activities at the event, such as the foot washing ([John 13:1–17](#)), Judas's betrayal ([13:18–30](#)), and the prediction of Peter's denials ([13:31–38](#)).

John 13:1–20.31

This section focuses on the sign of the cross, the great climax of Jesus' life, as well as the time Jesus spent preparing his disciples for it (chs [13–17](#)). Jesus is glorified through each event of these momentous days. Jesus' arrest, trial, crucifixion, and resurrection all evoke responses of awe. On the cross, Jesus is elevated in glory before the world ([12:32](#)).

John 13:2

Judas . . . Iscariot, who had refused to believe, was engulfed by darkness and had become Satan's pawn (cp. study note on [12:39–40](#)).

John 13:4–5

Foot washing, common in the Hellenistic and Jewish cultures as a daily routine and as a gesture of hospitality (see [Luke 7:36–50](#)), was a lowly, menial task reserved for servants. When Jesus

began to wash the disciples' feet, he took the posture of a slave.

John 13:8

Based on the depth of his devotion to Jesus, it is understandable that Peter protested. But Jesus was not simply giving Peter a model of service; this was a symbolic pre-enactment of his greater act of sacrifice on the cross ([13:7](#)). Receiving Jesus' spiritual cleansing is a condition for discipleship, so if Peter could not accept this act, he could not be Jesus' disciple at all.

John 13:9

wash my hands and head as well: Peter misunderstood Jesus (cp. [2:19–20](#); [3:3–4](#)). Peter thought that to have more water was to have more of Jesus. Only when Peter received the Spirit did everything become clear (e.g., see [Acts 2:14–36](#)).

John 13:10

Jesus referred to an ultimate cleansing through his sacrifice which makes a person clean all over.

John 13:14–15

Jesus' acts of service, such as washing feet and dying on the cross, provided an example of personal sacrifice to follow. • wash each other's feet: Foot washing was so commonplace that Jesus might have intended a literal repetition of his act, or he might have seen it as symbolic. Either way, Jesus wants similar servanthood and sacrifice to characterize his followers.

John 13:16

slaves are not greater than their master: This proverb was popular and appears in many places (see also [15:20](#); [Matt 10:24](#); [Luke 6:40](#)). Here, Jesus meant that the sacrifice modeled by the master should be seen in the life of the servant.

John 13:18

I am not saying these things to all of you: The subject of Judas's betrayal enters the story for the third time ([13:2](#), [11](#)). The matter weighed heavily on Jesus ([13:21](#)). • I know the ones I have chosen: The statement does not imply that Jesus chose only the eleven and that Judas was an outcast. Jesus chose Judas and gave him every opportunity to believe. He realized that Judas had embraced the darkness rather than the light ([6:70](#)). • The one who eats my food has turned against me (literally *has lifted his heel against me*): Eating together was a cultural symbol of personal intimacy, which made Judas's betrayal all the more treacherous.

John 13:19

Judas's betrayal did not take Jesus unaware, and it should not shock his disciples when it happens. • that I Am the Messiah: Literally *that I am*. By using the phrase "I am," Jesus clearly equated himself with the God of the Old Testament. See [Exod 3:14](#).

John 13:21

For the third time in the Gospel of John, Jesus was deeply troubled (Greek *tarassō*; see [11:33](#); [12:27](#)). The personal betrayal of Judas brought Jesus profound grief.

John 13:23

The disciple Jesus loved appears at the cross ([19:26-27](#)), at the tomb ([20:2-9](#)), and at the resurrection ([21:1](#), [20-23](#)). He is the author of this Gospel ([21:24-25](#)). Some scholars believe that Lazarus was in fact the disciple whom Jesus loved (see [11:3](#), [5](#), [36](#)), but the person referred to here was among the twelve apostles and is usually identified as the apostle John. • was sitting next to Jesus at the table: Literally *was reclining on Jesus' bosom*. They were probably reclining at a *triclinium*, a U-shaped table with couches. Guests reclined on the couches, while the center provided access to servers. The diners supported their bodies by their left elbows while using their right hands for eating. Feet were extended away from the table (cp. [Luke 7:38](#)).

John 13:25

Peter told "the disciple Jesus loved" ([13:23](#)), who was sitting next to Jesus, to ask the betrayer's identity. As he reclined next to Jesus, he leaned over to Jesus and spoke privately.

John 13:26

Meals included flat bread, which diners would dip into a common bowl. When Jesus gave a morsel to Judas (cp. [Ruth 2:14](#)), the disciples might have thought Jesus was honoring him. They did not understand what was occurring. They even thought that Judas's departure ([John 13:29](#)) fulfilled an official duty for the feast! But Jesus was signaling to Judas that he understood Judas's plan and was not taken by surprise. Jesus' knowledge is profound and complete (see [1:48](#); [2:25](#)).

John 13:27

When Satan entered into Judas (see [Luke 22:3](#)), Judas became an example of what happens to those who are consumed by the darkness. Satan uses such people as pawns in a wider struggle against the light. • Hurry and do what you're going to do: In issuing this command, Jesus once again showed that he was in control, not human beings or Satan (see study note on John 7:30).

John 13:28-29

None of the others suspected that something odd was happening. Passover evening was one of the only nights when the city gates were left open. The night was spent in prayer and meditation, money was given to the poor, and provisions were always needed for this complex meal.

John 13:30

out into the night: Judas's departure was emblematic: The darkness had swallowed him completely (see study note on 13:2; cp. [3:19](#)). Jesus, the light of the world, is the antithesis of the night.

John 13:31

The time has come: Judas's departure into the night marks a solemn divide in the plot of the Gospel. Jesus was left with his intimate friends as the hour of glory was dawning. This time was launched by Judas's betrayal, and it culminated in the resurrection.

John 13:31–17:26

The Old Testament and later Jewish literature include numerous examples of farewells in which a dying person offers last words to intimate friends (see [Gen 49:1–27](#); [Deut 31–34](#); [Josh 23–24](#); [1 Sam 12](#); [1 Chr 28:1–29:30](#)). Such farewells used a standard form. The dying person, surrounded by his loved ones, comforted them and exhorted them to obey the law. He prayed and blessed them and often left behind some writings. In some cases, the departing person passed on his “spirit” to his followers or his successor (see [Num 27:18](#); [Deut 34:9](#); [2 Kgs 2:9–14](#)). Each of these elements is present in Jesus' farewell. • This section is often called the Upper Room Discourse, since the meal was taken in an “upstairs room” ([Luke 22:12](#)).

John 13:33

Jesus addressed the apostles as his children, marking the start of his farewell address.

John 13:34–35

That the disciples were to love one another was not a new commandment (see [Lev 19:18](#)). However, that they were to love each other with the sort of love modeled by Jesus was dramatic. Jesus' love for God was expressed in perfect obedience ([John 14:31](#)); now this kind of love was his command—that disciples express their love for Jesus in committed obedience.

John 13:37

Peter claimed to be ready to die for Jesus, yet his denials are well known ([18:15–18](#), [25–27](#); see also [Matt 26:32–34](#); [Mark 14:27–30](#); [Luke 22:31–34](#)). Although Peter's verve and devotion failed, he was restored ([John 21:15–19](#)).

John 14:1

Jesus had himself been troubled (Greek *tarassō*) on three occasions ([11:33](#); [12:27](#); [13:21](#)). His confidence in God's power made it possible for him to face these crises. Faced with the upsetting words of [13:33](#), the disciples confronted similar feelings. • Trust (or *believe*, or *have faith*) in God: Only trusting God would help them through his hour of death.

John 14:1–31

Jesus provided answers to his disciples' many spoken and unspoken concerns.

John 14:2

There is more than enough room in my Father's home: God's house is the dwelling place where he resides ([Rev 21:9–22:5](#)). The word translated “room” is related to the Greek verb meaning “remain, abide, dwell.” Jesus promises that his followers will have a place to “dwell” alongside him, wherever he is. Later, this “dwelling” becomes a place of “indwelling” as Jesus makes his home in his followers' hearts through the Spirit ([John 14:23](#)).

John 14:3

Some scholars believe that Jesus meant he would come and get his followers after the resurrection ([14:18](#)). Others think these words refer to Jesus' second coming. For the disciples, the more important coming was Jesus' return from the grave (ch [16](#)).

John 14:6

I am: See study note on 6:35. Access to the Father's presence is only through Jesus, who is the way, the truth, and the life. • The way to the Father is only through Jesus. Other religions and philosophies propose different avenues to God, but Jesus asserted that he is the one exclusive path to God. • Jesus is the truth because God is truth. • God is the source of eternal life. At Lazarus's tomb, Jesus

showed his divine power over life and death ([11:25](#)).

John 14:8

Philip did not yet understand that in Jesus he was seeing the full embodiment of God ([14:9](#)).

John 14:9

Anyone who has seen me has seen the Father! Cp. [1:1-2](#). Jesus Christ is God-in-the-flesh ([1:14](#)), which explains his capacity to accomplish divine works. Jesus did not simply teach about God; in him God can be found. Jesus' remarkable statement echoed what he had said at Hanukkah: "The Father and I are one" ([10:30](#)). This claim is at the root of the world's opposition to Christ ([5:18](#)).

John 14:10

Jesus' claims were astonishing ([10:30](#), [37-38](#)). Yet true faith recognizes Jesus' union with God the Father.

John 14:12

Jesus promised that anyone who believes in him would perform great miracles and experience answers to their prayers (see [1 Jn 5:14](#)). These things would become possible when Jesus went to the Father, because he would send the Holy Spirit to empower the works ([John 14:16](#)). • The greater works will not outdo Jesus' work, but regular people empowered by the Spirit will be doing them. God promised that in the era of the Spirit, he would bring his Kingdom and power into the world in a way not seen before.

John 14:15

If you love me: Because Jesus loves the Father, he is obedient to what God directs him to say and do ([12:49](#)). If we love him, we will obey him too ([14:21](#), [23](#); [15:10](#), [14](#); see [1 Jn 2:3-4](#); [5:2](#)).

John 14:16

another Advocate: The Spirit continues Jesus' work by advising, defending, and protecting believers.

John 14:17

The Holy Spirit, who leads into all truth (literally *the Spirit of truth*; see also [15:26](#); [16:13](#)), communicates the truth about God. The Spirit maintains Jesus' presence in the world, duplicating and sustaining Jesus' work.

John 14:18

Jesus had already assured his followers that they would not be spiritual orphans and that he would return to them ([14:1-4](#)). While he is away, they will be filled with the Spirit, who will sustain them with his presence ([14:12-17](#)).

John 14:20

Jesus' resurrection ([14:19](#)) inaugurated his spiritual union with his disciples, which is parallel to the union he enjoys with the Father (see [15:4-5](#); [1 Jn 1:3](#)).

John 14:22

Several men are named Judas in the New Testament. Judas, the brother of Jesus, ([Mark 6:3](#)) wrote the epistle of Jude. Judas, the son of James, whom John is referring to here, is listed as an apostle in [Luke 6:16](#); he is elsewhere identified as Thaddaeus ([Matt 10:3](#); [Mark 3:18](#)). • Lord, why? Judas posed an important question. If Jesus planned to return mightily from death, why not use the opportunity to reveal himself definitively to the world and validate his power and identity?

John 14:23-24

Jesus answered Judas's question, explaining that his coming would be a profound spiritual revelation beyond the world's grasp. • Jesus' coming would occur in three experiences: his resurrection, the coming of the Spirit, and his second coming. When he comes in the Spirit, he and

the Father will reside within believers, making a home with each of them (see study note on 14:2).

John 14:26

Jesus promised to send the Holy Spirit (see also [14:16](#); [15:26](#); [16:7](#), [12-14](#)). • The Spirit will teach . . . everything, recalling Jesus' words and clarifying their meaning. John experienced this power as he wrote his Gospel ([2:22](#)); Christians experience this work of the Spirit as they read the Scriptures.

John 14:27

The Jewish greeting peace (Hebrew shalom) captured the spirit of Jesus' work on earth to restore humanity's relationship with God ([Isa 9:6-7](#); [52:7](#); [57:19](#); [Rom 5:1](#)). The resurrection ([John 14:28](#)) and the Spirit were instrumental in achieving this work.

John 14:28

the Father, who is greater than I am: See also [5:19-20](#). Jesus is submissive to the Father but is also one with the Father ([10:30](#)).

John 14:30

The events unfolding in Jerusalem that led to the cross were not controlled by the ruler of this world, meaning Satan. The cross was not an accident, and Jesus was not a helpless victim. Rather, Jesus was obedient to God's plan.

John 15:1

I am: See study note on 6:35. The grapevine and the vineyard traditionally represented God's people, planted and tended by him in Israel ([Ps 80:8-18](#); [Isa 5:1-7](#); [Jer 2:21](#); [12:10-11](#); [Ezek 15:1-5](#); [Hos 10:1-2](#)). When Jesus used this image, he made an important departure: He declared that he is the true grapevine and that a relationship with God requires attachment to him.

John 15:1-27

Jesus prepared his disciples for his departure, instructing them to remain in close fellowship with him. The image of a grapevine illustrates both intimacy and fruitfulness. To sustain genuine spiritual life in the world, believers must remain intimately connected to Christ.

John 15:2-3

Gardeners cut away dead branches and trim healthy branches so they will produce more fruit. Fruitfulness is the result of life-giving connection to the vine.

John 15:4

The term remain (Greek *menō*) is key to understanding [15:4-10](#). A growing disciple, in whom the Father and the Son live through the Spirit, must be continuously connected to Christ (see [14:16-25](#); [15:26](#)).

John 15:6

Anyone who does not remain in Christ is separated from the vine and its life. A living branch produces clusters of grapes ([15:5](#)). Connection with the vine allows the life of Jesus to flow fruitfully through the disciple. Those who claim to be attached to Christ but yield no fruit are useless and will be burned.

John 15:7

Those whose lives are in harmony with Jesus may ask for anything because their prayers are controlled by his word. Their prayers will be answered and bring glory to God ([14:10-13](#)).

John 15:8

True disciples will experience a transformed, fruit-bearing life because they live in a relationship of love with both Jesus and the Father ([15:9-10](#)).

John 15:10

Just as Jesus demonstrated his love for the Father by obeying his will ([14:31](#)), Jesus' disciples exhibit their love through obedience to him ([13:34-35](#); [14:15](#); [1 Jn 2:5](#); [5:2-3](#)).

John 15:12-13

This is my commandment: Love each other: See [13:34](#). • Jesus demonstrated his love by sacrificing his life at the cross.

John 15:14-16

Both Abraham and Moses were called friends of God ([Exod 33:11](#); [2 Chr 20:7](#); [Isa 41:8](#); [Jas 2:23](#)). This is the highest relationship possible between God and a person. Jesus chooses his friends ([John 15:16](#)), who demonstrate their friendship by obeying him.

John 15:15

The disciples of a rabbi were considered his servants or slaves. Jesus elevated his followers to a higher relationship as his friends.

John 15:18-27

Disciples must be like their master in every respect, both in showing love and obedience and in experiencing the antagonism of those who oppose their message ([15:20-21](#); see [9:1-41](#); [11:16](#)). If the darkness is opposed to the light ([1:5](#)), and if Jesus' followers are bearers of that light in the world ([1 Jn 1:7](#); [2:9](#)), they should expect the world to hate them in the way it hated Jesus (see [John 17:14](#)). Jesus' disciples share his separation from and conflict with the world.

John 15:20

A slave is not greater than the master: See study note on 13:16. Jesus' disciples should mirror him in every way, even in his experience of persecution and martyrdom.

John 15:22-24

But now they have no excuse: Jesus' ministry provided both words ([15:22](#)) and works ([15:24](#)) as evidence that pointed to God. Once people have heard and seen him, they are accountable.

John 15:25

They hated me without cause: This Old Testament citation reveals the unwarranted anger of those who belong to the darkness.

John 15:26

But I will send you the Advocate—the Spirit of truth: Like a legal advocate, the Holy Spirit counsels and protects Jesus' followers.

John 15:27

Disciples are not alone when they testify about Christ ([Matt 28:20](#)). The Spirit accompanies them, providing the words to say ([Matt 10:19-20](#)).

John 16:1-2

Jesus had outlined the coming conflicts ([15:18-25](#)) so that the disciples would not abandon their faith (literally *be caused to stumble*). The greatest obstacle his disciples would face was to stumble and renounce their faith before their opponents (see [Matt 23:34](#); [Luke 6:22](#)), especially during the dark days ahead (see [John 12:35](#); [1 Jn 2:9-11](#)).

John 16:7

the Advocate: The Spirit was a gift awaiting Jesus' departure and glorification ([7:37-39](#); [14:16](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:12-14](#)).

John 16:8

The Spirit unveils to the world the real nature of its sin, the truth about righteousness found only in God, and the coming judgment, which has already dawned on the world as light penetrating the darkness.

John 16:8–11

One of the Spirit's roles is to convict the world. Convict is a legal term: The world had conducted its trial of Jesus, examining the evidence for his case (his signs and claims). Now the world would stand trial before the Spirit, and its guilt would be proven.

John 16:11

Judgment of sinners had already begun, for the ruler of this world, Satan, had already been judged (see [12:31](#)). The world thought it was judging Jesus, but the opposite occurred.

John 16:13

The Spirit of truth, who conveys truth from God, guides the judgment of the world. • The Spirit says only what he has heard from the Father. The Father, Son, and Spirit work in perfect unity ([16:15](#)). The disciples could expect the Spirit to reveal things they had not heard before about the present and the future (see [14:26](#)).

John 16:16

Jesus reassured the disciples that his departure (on the cross) would be short and his return (in the resurrection) would be soon. When they saw him again, the disciples would experience overwhelming joy and intimacy with him in the Spirit.

John 16:16–33

a little while: This refrain reassured the disciples that their separation from Jesus would be short-lived.

John 16:20

At the crucifixion, the world thought it had won a victory over the light. The shock of the cross would cause the disciples to weep and mourn, but their sorrow would change to joy when Jesus defeated the grave ([20:20](#)).

John 16:21

the pains of labor: This metaphor symbolizes anguish that is followed by God's blessing and wonder (cp. [Isa 21:2–3](#); [26:16–21](#); [66:7–10](#); [Jer 13:21](#)).

John 16:23–24

Ask . . . and you will receive: Two notable effects of the resurrection are the joy of understanding and the joy of successful prayer. The disciples would no longer experience the confusion described in [16:16–18](#).

John 16:25

Jesus spoke using figures of speech, which could only be interpreted with God's help ([1 Cor 1:18–25](#)). With the coming of the Spirit, the disciples would understand.

John 16:26–27

After Jesus' resurrection, the Spirit brought intimacy, allowing individual disciples to ask the Father to meet their needs. ([14:23](#)).

John 16:33

But take heart, because I have overcome the world: "Such a saying as this is worthy to be carried from Rome to Jerusalem on one's knees" (Martin Luther). Jesus' final words did not chastise but brought comfort. Jesus promised peace ([14:27](#)) and joy ([16:20, 22](#)). Now he added that his disciples can discover peace even when surrounded by threats; they can be tranquil despite those who are hostile to their faith.

John 17:1

Jesus looked up to heaven, assuming the traditional Jewish posture for prayer ([11:41](#); [Ps 123:1](#)). He probably also raised his hands ([Exod 9:33](#); [17:11](#); [Ps 28:2](#)). Prayers like this were said aloud so that followers could hear ([John 11:41–42](#); [12:27–30](#)).

also [Matt 11:25–30](#); [Luke 10:21–22](#)). • Father was Jesus' usual way to address God, which he did six times in this prayer (see also [John 11:41](#); [12:27](#)). This title—unusual in Judaism—reflected Jesus' intimacy with God. • This hour included Jesus' betrayal, arrest, torture, death, and resurrection (see study note on 12:23). • Glorify your Son: In the Gospel of John, the cross is a place of honor. Jesus' oneness with the Father means that if the Son is glorified, the Father will also be glorified.

John 17:1–26

This chapter records Jesus' longest prayer, which is often called his "high priestly prayer." It provides an intimate glimpse into his heart. In this prayer, which closes the farewell that began at [13:31](#), Jesus expressed his own concerns to his Father ([17:1–8](#)) and then turned to concerns for the church and its future ([17:9–26](#)).

John 17:2

All authority has been placed in Jesus' hands ([3:35](#)); he can give eternal life as only God can ([3:15](#); [5:21](#), [25–26](#)).

John 17:3

- *that they may know you*: In the Hebrew language, "knowing" includes experience and intimacy. For Christians, this means loving God and obeying him.
- *whom You have sent*: Jesus came from heaven and was returning ([John 17:5](#)). So he has divine authority as God's agent.

John 17:4

Jesus' miracles displayed God's glory for the world to see ([1:14](#)). This task was finished; Jesus' life and obedience had glorified God.

John 17:5

Jesus prayed to return to the position he had with God before the world began ([1:1](#)).

John 17:6

This verse summarizes Christ's mission. He revealed the true person of God to the world, gathered up God's people into his flock, and instructed them in obedience. The result of this work is the church.

John 17:8

Jesus revealed himself widely to the world. Those who embraced his message became children of God ([1:12](#); [11:52](#)), and he revealed God's word to them.

John 17:9–19

Jesus prayed for his disciples, who must carry on after his departure.

John 17:10

Just as the Son brings glory to the Father ([17:1](#), [4–5](#)), the disciples bring the Son glory ([17:22](#)). The love and obedience that brought glory to God in Jesus' life become features of his disciples' lives.

John 17:11

Jesus' first concern for his disciples was that they . . . be united with an intimacy similar to the oneness shared by Jesus and the Father.

John 17:12–13

Until now, Jesus had guarded his followers. Now he was concerned for their strength and survival in his absence, because the world would be hostile toward them ([15:18–27](#)) and their mission of challenging the world by heralding the truth ([16:8–11](#)). After Jesus' departure, the Spirit would protect them ([15:26](#)) and bring them joy.

John 17:14

God's word, which Jesus had given his disciples, also provides a defense against the world. The Spirit would preserve and recall God's word in the church ([14:26](#)), equipping the church for its encounter with the world.

John 17:16-18

Being holy refers to purity gained by separation from the world, and living a life so aligned with God that it reflects his passions. Disciples are set apart by God, equipped by the Spirit, and readied by God's word to enter the world without being victimized by its darkness.

John 17:19

I give myself as a holy sacrifice (literally *I sanctify myself*): Priests and prophets were similarly set apart for service to God ([Lev 8:30](#); [Jer 1:5](#)). Jesus recommitted himself to his mission, acknowledging that he was set apart for the purpose of the cross. The disciples would benefit because his death would enable them to experience new holiness in a deep attachment to God.

John 17:20

Jesus was praying for other sheep who were not yet in his flock ([10:16](#)). These are the believers through the centuries who have come to faith through the witness of Jesus' disciples.

John 17:21

For believers, becoming one with one another is an outgrowth of the union they enjoy with Jesus himself, a union modeled on the oneness of the Father and the Son. • may they be in us: Through the power of the Spirit, believers would experience a profound spiritual intimacy with the Father and the Son and be transformed ([14:20, 23](#); [1 Jn 4:13](#)). • Disciples of Jesus represent him, so their conduct and relationships with each other reflect the credibility of Christ in the world. When there is disunity, infighting, and intolerance, their testimony to the world is unconvincing. When people observe the community of believers, they

know that it represents Jesus; a unified, loving community convinces the world to believe ([John 13:35](#); [1 Jn 3:11](#)).

John 17:22

The community of believers should display the same glory that Jesus displayed from the Father.

John 17:23

that the world will know: If the church lives in the Spirit, reflects God's glory and love, and shows unity sustained by a shared knowledge of God, then its testimony will astonish the world.

John 17:24

I want these . . . to be with me: Someday, Jesus' followers will see Jesus' true glory, the true love that has existed in heaven since the beginning of time ([17:5](#)). Jesus was returning to heaven, and he yearned to see his disciples there so that they might glimpse what no words on earth can describe.

John 17:26

All who accept the Son and embrace the Father will experience the kind of love known only between the Father and the Son. • I will be in them: Jesus loves his followers and wants to indwell them with glory and joy unmatched by anything in the world.

John 18:1-2

Jesus crossed the Kidron Valley, a dry river valley (a *wadi*) outside Jerusalem's walls on the city's east edge. • The Garden of Gethsemane ([Mark 14:32](#)) was a grove of olive trees that grew along the west shoulder of the Mount of Olives (*gath shemany* means "olive press" in Aramaic). Jesus liked this place and frequently prayed there (see [John 8:1](#); [Luke 21:37](#); [22:39](#)).

John 18:1–40

After completing his farewell in the upper room ([13:31–17:26](#)), Jesus left the city and entered a garden just east of Jerusalem to pray. Here he was arrested, taken under guard into the city, and interrogated by the Jewish leaders. The climactic “time” that Jesus referred to repeatedly throughout the Gospel (see [2:4](#); see also study note on 12:23) was now at hand.

John 18:3

John’s full description of the arresting party expands the picture from the other Gospels. The Temple authorities sent Roman soldiers and Temple guards; while the Temple guards made the arrest, the Roman detachment stood by to prevent a riot. The Roman detachment was large enough to warrant a commander ([18:12](#)) and came armed, anticipating a struggle ([18:10](#)). Numerous men had claimed to be the Messiah, and often they had made politically explosive attempts to expel the Romans.

John 18:5

I Am he (literally *I am*): Jesus identified himself by the divine name God had revealed to Moses on Mount Sinai (see [Exod 3:14](#); see also [John 4:26](#); [8:24](#), [58](#)).

John 18:6

The soldiers and guards all drew back before the Lord (cp. [Isa 6:5](#); [Ezek 1:28](#); [Dan 10:9](#); [Acts 9:4](#); [Rev 1:17](#)). Even Roman soldiers, who were trained not to fall, fell to the ground before Christ. Although they took this posture of submission, they didn’t really understand what had occurred and proceeded with the arrest.

John 18:8

I Am: Jesus used God’s divine name for the second time (see study note on 18:5).

John 18:9

I did not lose a single one: Jesus continued to be a good shepherd, offering his life for the sheep and protecting them from the wolves ([10:11–15](#)). From the beginning, however, Judas Iscariot had not been a true disciple of Jesus ([17:12](#)).

John 18:10–11

Simon Peter drew a short sword or a long knife that was generally worn with everyday garments. • The Hebrew name Malchus means “king,” a detail that John might have included for its wordplay on Jesus’ true identity (see [18:36–37](#); [19:19](#)). • Put your sword back: Jesus’ mission was not to fight for his life, but to die for ours.

John 18:12–14

Jesus was bound by the soldiers and returned to Jerusalem. • First they took him to Annas, who had been the high priest and remained highly influential (five of his sons also became high priests). Caiaphas, his son-in-law, was the official high priest at that time (see [18:24](#)).

John 18:14

one man should die for the people: Caiaphas had previously made this political analysis ([11:49–50](#)). John points out the irony of this statement. Jesus’ death did not bring Israel political salvation—it brought spiritual salvation to all who believe.

John 18:15

That other disciple is unnamed but was probably the “disciple Jesus loved” ([13:23](#))—John, the author of this Gospel.

John 18:16–17

During Jesus’ interrogation by Annas ([18:12–14](#), [19–24](#)), the woman watching at the gate asked Peter if he was one of that man’s disciples. In contrast to Jesus, who stood up to his questioners and denied nothing, Peter quickly denied his link to Jesus three times ([18:17](#), [25](#), [27](#)).

John 18:19

The high priest began asking Jesus questions, but his inquiry was contrary to Jewish legal procedure. In Jewish court, the priest did not ask questions directly of the defendant but accumulated evidence from witnesses to establish guilt (see [Num 35:30](#); [Deut 17:6](#); [19:15](#); cp. [Matt 18:16](#)). If Jesus said anything incriminating, Annas would later use it to testify against him at Jesus' trial. He was attempting to follow Roman practice by making Jesus incriminate himself, rather than gathering evidence through witnesses as Jewish law demanded.

John 18:20–21

Jesus' sharp answer, reminding Annas that everything was in the public record, unmasked the priest's attempt to follow Roman practice.

John 18:22–23

When Jesus reminded Annas of correct judicial procedure, one of the Temple guards viewed it as insolence and slapped Jesus. However, Jesus knew the law and represented it truthfully. No witnesses were accusing him, and no evidence was being presented.

John 18:24

Annas was at an impasse—his probing had been unsuccessful. So he sent Jesus to Caiaphas to be prosecuted before the Sanhedrin, Jerusalem's judicial high council (see [Mark 14:53–15:1](#)).

John 18:25–27

He denied it: Peter's three denials were later echoed when Jesus invited him three times to reaffirm his love ([21:15–17](#)).

John 18:28

The trial before Caiaphas ended in the early hours of the morning. Since they did not have the power

of capital punishment ([18:31](#)), the Sanhedrin needed to enlist Pilate, the Roman governor, to carry out an execution. • it would defile them: They did not want to become ritually unclean by contact with Gentiles in Pilate's headquarters. So Pilate, probably fearing a riot, went outside to meet them. • The Passover meal itself had occurred the night before (see [13:1](#); [Mark 14:14–16](#)). The following day, another meal began the weeklong Festival of Unleavened Bread ([Lev 23:5–6](#)).

John 18:29

Pilate, the fifth Roman governor of Judea, ruled the country from AD 26 to 36. He usually lived on the coast in Caesarea, but kept troops stationed in a fortress in Jerusalem where he appeared personally for major festivals. He was a brutal ruler whose atrocities against the Jews were legendary (e.g., [Luke 13:1](#); Josephus, *War* 2.9.2–4).

John 18:31–32

Pilate found the charges unsatisfying and told the Sanhedrin, judge him by your own law. Pilate saw this as a Jewish squabble, which he refused to investigate. The Jewish leaders, however, insisted that an execution was necessary. • fulfilled Jesus' prediction about the way he would die (see [12:32–33](#)): The Jews would have employed stoning; the Romans used crucifixion. If Pilate delivered Jesus' sentence, he would be crucified.

John 18:33

Pilate was personally responsible for capital crimes in which the interests and security of the Roman Empire were at stake, so he began his formal legal inquiry. • Are you the king of the Jews? To get the governor's attention, Caiaphas had charged that Jesus had urged people not to pay their taxes to the Roman government and had claimed to be a king ([Luke 23:2](#)). To Pilate, Jesus might have been just another Jewish terrorist-revolutionary (see [Luke 23:18–19](#); [Acts 5:36–37](#)) with a head full of messianic notions and a band of well-armed followers.

John 18:34–35

Jesus' reply forced the governor to show the origin of his question. The Temple leadership was behind these charges. Pilate only wanted to know if Jesus was a rebel who might threaten Roman interests.

John 18:36–37

Jesus was willing to accept the title of king, but he made it clear that he did not govern an earthly kingdom that might rival Rome. Jesus' kingship is not of this world. Rather than being a political ruler, he rules through the devotion and obedience of his followers.

John 18:38–39

What is truth? Truth was not a foreign idea to Pilate, but he did not wait for an answer to his question because he did not believe there was one.

- Pilate returned to the council members waiting outside and delivered his verdict: not guilty. Although he referred to Jesus as "King of the Jews" (see also [19:19](#)), the title meant nothing more to Pilate than a mocking expression of contempt. Pilate's offer of amnesty revealed his desire to let Jesus go.

John 18:40

Jesus was no threat to Rome, but Barabbas was a revolutionary, a violent man who took part in political uprisings (see [Luke 23:19](#)), with a proven capacity to challenge the Roman military occupation of Israel.

John 19:1–16

Jesus was also beaten after his sentencing ([Mark 15:15](#)), but here John records an earlier beating, which was likely Pilate's attempt to show that Jesus had been punished and could be released ([John 19:4](#)). When this failed, Pilate passed his sentence and handed Jesus over to the Jewish leaders for crucifixion ([19:16](#)).

John 19:2

The crown of thorns might have come from a date palm (cp. [12:13–14](#)), the thorns of which can exceed twelve inches. There are Greek coin images showing such crowns, with the stems woven and the thorns radiating upward above the crown. • The purple robe was probably a soldier's robe—dark red to complete the picture of mock royalty.

John 19:4–6

Pilate's intention was to bring Jesus out to display the marks of his punishment to sway the crowd to let him go. After being flogged with a lead-tipped whip, Jesus was bleeding profusely. • Pilate announced his verdict of not guilty a second time, but he was met with a strident call for Jesus' death ([19:6](#)).

John 19:6

Pilate knew that a riot could happen when a man popular with the masses was executed, so he shifted responsibility to crucify Jesus to the Temple leaders.

John 19:7

During the trial before Caiaphas, the charge of blasphemy—calling himself the Son of God—was determined to be Jesus' true crime (see [Mark 14:61–65](#)). • The leaders had already tried pitting Jesus against Roman imperial interests ([John 18:33](#)), and would do so again ([19:12](#)). Now they challenged the governor on another level: Pilate must keep the peace by upholding local law, even when it was irrelevant to Rome. Claiming to be God's son was not illegal, because Israel's kings did this ([Pss 2:7; 89:22–27](#)). However, Jesus claimed to have the divine authority of God himself (see [John 5:18](#)), which they saw as blasphemy.

John 19:8–9

Pilate . . . was more frightened than ever: He was superstitious, and the idea of gods appearing in the world was not uncommon ([Acts 14:11](#)). He sensed that more than a political fight was going on, so he asked Jesus, Where are you from? He did not mean

Jesus' birthplace, but whether Jesus was a divine man who had descended from heaven. • Why Jesus gave no answer is unclear. Perhaps it was because Pilate would not have been able to understand the answer—that true power comes only from God, and God had empowered Jesus (cp. [John 19:11](#)).

John 19:10–11

You would have no power over me: Although Pilate had the power to . . . crucify Jesus, it was only because God had given him this temporary power so Jesus could advance toward the cross (see [10:18](#)).

John 19:12

Each time he had a conversation with Jesus, Pilate tried to release him: He kept trying, but his repeated efforts were fruitless. • “Friend of Caesar” was an official title given to individuals such as senators who showed exceptional loyalty and service to the emperor. The Jewish leaders were implying that they would ruin Pilate’s career by reporting that he was not working in Rome’s interests. They probably knew that Pilate was also having a personal crisis. His patron in Rome, Sejanus (the chief administrator of the empire under Tiberius Caesar), had fallen from favor and was executed in AD 31. Pilate had every reason to be afraid.

John 19:13

Pilate took the governor’s judgment seat (Greek *bēma*, cp. [Acts 25:6](#), “seat in court”) to render his verdict. • The Stone Pavement was the platform holding the judgment seat; from there Pilate now spoke with the authority of his office.

John 19:14

the day of preparation for the Passover (or *the day of preparation during the Passover*): Here, Passover does not refer to the Jewish Passover meal, which had taken place the night before, but to the whole Festival of Unleavened Bread. It was now Friday, the day of preparation for the Passover Sabbath, which would begin at sundown (cp. [Mark 15:42](#); [Luke 23:54](#)).

John 19:15

The final words of the priests, “We have no king but Caesar,” stood in direct contradiction to the Old Testament understanding that God was Israel’s king (cp. [Judg 8:23](#); [1 Sam 8:7](#); [10:19](#)). Jerusalem and its leaders were in the process of killing their true king ([John 18:37](#)) while paying homage to Caesar, the pagan king of Rome.

John 19:16

Pilate turned Jesus over to the Roman garrison, who prepared Jesus for crucifixion by a second flogging ([Mark 15:15](#)), which brought him near death. Bleeding profusely, his clothes soaked in blood, his thorn-laced crown now digging deeply into his head, and nearly in shock, Jesus was marched to a site outside the city.

John 19:17

The vertical beam (Latin *staticulum*) of the cross was generally kept at the crucifixion site, and the victim was forced to carry only the heavy crossbeam (Latin *patibulum*). • Crucifixions were public executions that took place near major roadways. They were designed to shock and warn the people. • Place of the Skull (Hebrew and Aramaic *Golgotha*; Latin *calvariae*, “Calvary”): Most archaeologists agree that Jesus’ crucifixion was at the site of the present-day Church of the Holy Sepulchre, located in the Christian Quarter of the old walled city of Jerusalem. An alternate site, Gordon’s Calvary (north of the Damascus Gate), provides a model of what the scene possibly looked like, but it holds only a tomb from the 500s BC and therefore is unlikely to be the authentic site of Jesus’ crucifixion and burial.

John 19:18

None of the Gospel writers dwell on the details of being nailed . . . to the cross because they were well known and horrific. The soldiers used the cross as a means of torture; they wanted victims to survive for a while, in some cases for days. Because the Sabbath would begin at dusk ([19:31](#)), they expedited Jesus’ crucifixion. Jesus had been

thoroughly beaten with stone- or metal-tipped whips, so his back was thoroughly lacerated, and he was bleeding profusely.

John 19:19–22

Pilate posted a sign on the cross: It was customary for the Roman soldiers to provide a written public notice of the criminal's name and crimes. Perhaps as a final act of revenge against the Jewish high council, Pilate ordered that the sign should identify Jesus of Nazareth as the King of the Jews. Jesus' kingship was posted in three languages for the whole world to understand.

John 19:23–24

As was their common practice, the Roman soldiers divided his clothes. The soldiers gambled for his valuable robe, which was seamless, rather than dividing it up.

John 19:25–26

This is the only reference to Jesus' mother's sister in the New Testament. She might have been the wife of Zebedee and the mother of James and John (cp. [Matt 27:56](#)), which would make Jesus and John cousins. If so, it would help explain why Jesus assigned the disciple he loved (John) to care for Mary (John's aunt). • Mary (the wife of Clopas) is only mentioned here. She might be the same person as Mary the mother of James and Joseph (cp. [Matt 27:56](#)). • Jesus had healed Mary Magdalene, a woman from the village of Magdala ([Mark 16:9](#); [Luke 8:2](#)). • Dear woman was a formal and polite form of address (see [John 2:4](#)).

John 19:27

Here is your mother: Jesus employed a Jewish family law that assigned the care of one person to another. The scene had an additional significance: The people who were present represented the new community of the church that was born at the cross. Jesus wanted them to care for each other in obedience to his command to love one another ([13:34](#); [15:12](#), [17](#)).

John 19:29

The hyssop bush had been used in Egypt to brush lamb's blood on the doorposts and lintels during the first Passover ([Exod 12:22](#)). Jesus is God's Passover lamb ([John 1:29](#), [36](#)), and his blood likewise saves.

John 19:30

Jesus called out in triumph and exhaustion that he had finished the work he set out to do. On the cross he was not a victim, but a servant doing God's bidding.

John 19:31–33

The Jewish authorities, eager to complete the crucifixion before Sabbath began at dusk, asked Pilate to break the legs of the men. Breaking the legs with a mallet was common: It promoted asphyxiation and hemorrhaging, because the victim could no longer push up to breathe.

John 19:34

To confirm that Jesus was dead, a Roman soldier pierced his side with a spear. • blood and water flowed out: This has several levels of meaning: (1) The spear probably punctured Jesus' pericardium, the sac around the heart, releasing these fluids. (2) John might have been thinking of more Passover symbolism. The Passover lamb's blood had to flow as it died. (3) The water flowing from Jesus' side reminds readers of the language of living water that Jesus had used earlier (see [4:10–14](#); [7:37–39](#)).

John 19:35

John was at the foot of the cross ([19:26](#)). He was not simply a collector of traditions about Jesus, but an eyewitness giving an accurate account of the events of Jesus' life (cp. [21:24](#)). This same confidence can be seen in the opening of John's first letter ([1 Jn 1:1–4](#)).

John 19:36

“Not one of his bones will be broken”: The Passover lamb could have no broken bones ([Exod 12:46](#); [Num 9:12](#)); Jesus was the perfect Passover lamb (cp. [Ps 34:20](#); see also [1 Cor 5:7](#)).

John 19:37

“They will look on the one they pierced”: [Zechariah 12:10](#) describes how Israel would look on a prophet or the Messiah and lament their own fatal lack of faith.

John 19:38

According to Luke, Joseph of Arimathea was a courageous man who was waiting for the Kingdom of God ([Luke 23:50–51](#)). He was a wealthy ([Matt 27:57](#)) and influential leader in Jerusalem and a member of the high council ([Mark 15:43](#)) who disagreed with the decision to kill Jesus. He asked Pilate for the favor of burying Jesus in his personal tomb. • Joseph was a secret disciple (cp. [John 12:42–43](#)), but his bold deed brought out his public support of Jesus.

John 19:39

Nicodemus (see [3:1](#); [7:50](#)), a member of the high council, understood that these bodies had to be buried before the upcoming Sabbath ([19:31, 42](#)). His public support, as with Joseph of Arimathea, might indicate that he, too, was becoming a disciple (see study note on 7:49–51). • Myrrh was a commonly used aromatic powder. • The aloes were fragrant powdered sandalwood often used as perfume. • seventy-five pounds: This enormous amount of spices was appropriate for royalty; Jesus, the king, was given a royal burial.

John 19:41

a new tomb: More than 900 first-century burial tombs have been discovered in Judea, carved into the limestone hills.

John 19:42

because it was the day of preparation for the Jewish Passover: See study note on 19:14. The Sabbath was approaching, so Joseph and Nicodemus ([19:38–39](#)) would return to complete the burial process later.

John 20:1

As a devoted follower of Jesus (see [Matt 27:55–56](#); [Luke 8:1–3](#)), Mary Magdalene arrived at the tomb to help complete Jesus’ burial (see [John 19:42](#)). • Many Judean tombs were sealed with a rolling stone.

John 20:2

Mary Magdalene ran and found Simon Peter. Her natural assumption was that someone had robbed the tomb and perhaps stolen the body—which was not an uncommon occurrence.

John 20:3–10

The other disciple was probably John, “the disciple Jesus loved” and author of this Gospel (see [13:23](#)). He and Peter validated Mary’s testimony by examining the tomb for themselves. John arrived first, but Peter entered first.

John 20:6–7

What Peter and John found in the tomb was remarkable. The linen wrappings ([19:40](#)) were on the burial bench. Jews also used a facial cloth for burials (cp. [11:44](#)), which was rolled, wrapped under the chin, and tied on the top of the head. The apostles found this face cloth folded up on the bench. John’s inclusion of these details counters any suggestion that grave robbers had taken Jesus’ body; such costly garments would have been stolen in a robbery.

John 20:8–9

he saw and believed: Despite not fully understanding, John knew that God had been at work, and he realized that Jesus was alive.

John 20:11–13

Although two . . . angels appeared inside the tomb, the riddle of Jesus' disappearance remained unsolved (see [Luke 24:4](#)). • why are you crying? Sorrow was not the appropriate response in this moment.

John 20:14–15

Jesus, whom Mary mistook for the gardener, repeated the angel's question and added, Who are you looking for? Jesus' question was to provoke Mary's thinking: At this point Mary was looking for the body of Jesus, but she was about to meet the living Christ.

John 20:16

When Jesus called Mary by name, she recognized him immediately (see [10:3–4](#)).

John 20:17

Mary thought that with the resurrection, Jesus would resume normal relations with his disciples. She was trying to cling to the joy she discovered in her resurrected Lord. But his fellowship with her would come in a new form ([20:22](#)). Jesus had not yet ascended to complete his return to the Father, but the process was underway. Before his final departure, he would give the Holy Spirit ([20:22](#); see [14:15–21](#), [26](#); [15:26–27](#); [16:5–15](#)).

John 20:18

Mary was the first eyewitness to see the Lord following his resurrection. She not only saw him, she heard him and touched him (see [1 Jn 1:1–4](#)). This great privilege was given to a woman whose broken life had experienced healing ([Luke 8:2](#)). In Jewish culture this was astounding; a woman could not even be a witness in court. No Jew in this period would make up such a story.

John 20:19

meeting behind locked doors: The disciples feared prosecution for following Jesus. • Peace be with you: This was a standard Jewish greeting (see also [3 Jn 1:15](#)), but Jesus was doing more than just greeting his disciples: he was offering the Messiah's peace (see [Isa 9:6](#); [52:7](#)) and delivering the gift of his Kingdom (see [John 14:27](#); [16:33](#)).

John 20:20

The reality of Jesus' resurrection was quite clear. Jesus showed them the wounds from the nails and the spear. He did not feign death but conquered it. He was no phantom but a real man with a real body. He had been dead but was now alive. Jesus was fully human both in life ([1:14](#)) and in his resurrection.

John 20:21

I am sending you: God had sent Jesus into the world to establish his Kingdom, and now Jesus was sending his disciples to carry on his mission. Christ's emissaries carry the truth of Jesus' words to the world (cp. [17:18](#)).

John 20:22

Jesus commissioned the disciples and then empowered them with the Holy Spirit. The Spirit had not been given previously because Jesus had not yet been glorified ([7:39](#)). The glorified Jesus, resplendent in his resurrected body, poured the Spirit on his followers. This gift fulfilled many promises that the Spirit would be sent ([14:16](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7](#), [13](#)). It foreshadows the arrival of the Spirit's empowering presence at Pentecost ([Acts 1:4–5](#); [2:1–47](#)).

John 20:23

If you forgive anyone's sins: The ongoing work of Christ's followers parallels the work of Christ. Christ's followers do not distribute and withdraw God's forgiveness on a whim, but they follow Jesus' prompting through the Spirit ([15:5](#)), just as Jesus obeyed his Father ([14:31](#)).

John 20:24–25

Thomas: See also [11:16](#); [14:5](#)). Thomas was absent when Jesus revealed himself. He remained skeptical despite the testimony of his friends, who had seen the Lord. Thomas demanded a concrete experience identical to theirs.

John 20:26–27

Eight days later was Sunday, one week after Jesus' resurrection (it was customary to include the current day when counting forward). Jesus' appearance on the following Sunday helps explain the disciples' meeting on "the Lord's Day" (see [Rev 1:10](#)). • Peace be with you: This scene was exactly like Jesus' first appearance ([John 20:19–20](#)). Jesus had already heard Thomas's complaint and now answered directly. • Believe! Jesus challenged Thomas to believe in the resurrection like the others.

John 20:28

"My Lord and my God!" This was not an astonished exclamation but a proclamation of heartfelt belief. It concludes John's declaration of Jesus' deity that has framed the whole book (see [1:1–18](#)).

John 20:29

Jesus points to the generations of Christians who, through the testimony of others, would believe without seeing.

John 20:30–31

Many scholars view these words as the conclusion of John's Gospel, viewing [ch 21](#) as an appendix. John's account is only a selection from Jesus' many . . . miraculous signs.

John 20:31

that you may continue to believe: The present tense (found in some manuscripts) indicates that John wrote to encourage believers. Other manuscripts read *that you may [come to] believe*, suggesting that John wrote to stimulate new faith (cp. [1:7](#)).

John 21:1–25

This final chapter adds an account about the resurrected Jesus in Galilee ([21:1–14](#)) and records the exchange between Peter and Jesus concerning Peter's love ([21:15–23](#)). The chapter ends by summarizing the authority and importance of John's eyewitness report ([21:24–25](#)).

John 21:2

Several of the disciples returned to fishing in the Sea of Galilee. This was not a sign that their faith had weakened—even rabbis who regularly preached kept practicing their occupations (see [Acts 18:3](#); [20:34](#); [1 Cor 4:12](#)). • The sons of Zebedee were James and John (see [Matt 4:21](#)).

John 21:3

Fishing was usually successful in the early hours of the morning. However, this trip was useless and they caught nothing all night.

John 21:4

Jesus was standing on the beach, but the men did not recognize him (cp. [20:11–16](#); [Luke 24:13–53](#)).

John 21:6

"Throw out your net on the right-hand side": Casting a net into the sea at random was futile. But when they did as the stranger said, the immense catch was immediate ([21:11](#)).

John 21:7

"It's the Lord!" John recognized Jesus, probably remembering that a miracle like this had happened before ([Luke 5:1–11](#)). • Peter, who had stripped off his clothes while working, put on his tunic in order to meet the Lord.

John 21:9

Cooked fish and bread were the mainstays of the Galilean diet; Jesus provided the men with breakfast. The charcoal fire is reminiscent of the scene of Peter's denials ([18:18](#)).

John 21:11

This miracle showed generous provision (as in [2:1-12](#); [6:1-15](#)). No symbolism attaches to the number 153.

John 21:12-13

None of the disciples dared to ask him, "Who are you?" Jesus' resurrected appearance was different. His offer of fish and bread removed all uncertainties (cp. [6:11](#); [Luke 24:30](#)).

John 21:14

This scene on the beach was the third time Jesus had appeared (see [20:11-23](#), [26-29](#)).

John 21:15

more than these? Or *more than these others do*? Jesus was reminding Peter of his insistence that he would be more faithful and courageous than the others ([13:37](#); [Matt 26:33](#); [Mark 14:29](#)). He was urging Peter to examine himself.

John 21:15-17

do you love me? The three questions and affirmations mirror Peter's three denials ([18:15-18](#), [25-27](#)). Jesus invited Peter to reaffirm everything he had denied. • The Greek term translated love in Jesus' first two questions (*agapaō*) is different from the word in his third question (*phileō*). In each case, Peter answered with the second word (*phileō*). Most Greek scholars view the two words as synonyms in this situation. The focus of Jesus' exchange with Peter was not the quality of Peter's love, but Peter's commission to take care of Jesus' flock. Peter might be meditating on these events in [1 Pet 5:2-4](#).

John 21:17

feed my sheep: Jesus, who knows all things ([1:42](#); [2:25](#); [16:30](#)), understood that despite Peter's terrible failing, he still had faith and commitment to Jesus. These words called Peter to nurture and protect Christ's followers.

John 21:18

you will stretch out your hands: Jesus was probably predicting crucifixion, which according to tradition is how Peter died. • others will dress you (literally *bind you*): Jesus alludes to captivity, bondage, and even crucifixion—victims were often tied to the cross.

John 21:19

The rest of Peter's life was a ministry tending the flock of God, and his martyrdom was a kind of death that glorifies God. • Follow me: This might require suffering and death (see [13:16](#); [15:18-21](#)).

John 21:20-22

"What about him, Lord?" Peter asked Jesus about the fate of John, wondering if he, too, would experience martyrdom. Jesus' answer was abrupt: It was not Peter's business to know how or when John would die. Peter's only task was to follow Jesus, which John was already doing. This episode forms the core of John's concept of discipleship: What matters most for the disciple of Jesus is to follow him and do his will, come what may.

John 21:23

Jesus' words to Peter spread, causing some to conclude that John would not die until Jesus returned in his second coming. Jesus' rebuke to Peter ([21:22](#)) is repeated to answer that rumor. Those among the community of believers who believed this rumor were thus instructed to abandon any speculation about John. According to tradition, John died peacefully in Ephesus at an old age, surrounded by fellow believers.

John 21:24

This disciple is the one who testifies . . . and has recorded: John's Gospel is anchored in his personal experiences. It is not a story written from hearsay or speculation, but from the remembrance of a man who spent life-changing years with Jesus and recalled, with the help of the Holy Spirit ([14:26](#)), what Jesus said and did. • we know: This account of the life of Christ was not speculation or weak reminiscence. Rather, it was based on the confident knowledge of reliable eyewitness accounts.

John 21:25

the whole world could not contain the books: John ends his Gospel acknowledging that the story he has described is larger than anything he can imagine or fully communicate. Though it is glorious for us to read, John's account pales in comparison to the glory of the person it describes.